Provably Retain-Safe Machine Unlearning via Gradient Projection

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Abstract

Machine unlearning must remove a class's influence from a trained network without damaging what the network should keep—a forget–retain trade-off dual to the stability–plasticity trade-off of continual learning. We adapt A-GEM's gradient projection so that every unlearning step lies in the retain-safe half-space $\{u : \langle u, g_r \rangle \geq 0\}$, and apply it to the post-momentum update the optimiser actually takes rather than to the raw gradient. The resulting per-step retain-safety guarantee is exact for the deployed optimiser; removing momentum to simplify the analysis instead leaves forget accuracy far above chance on five of six datasets. EXCISE pairs the projected update with a retain-confusion forget objective and stopping rules derived from explicit tolerances. Across six datasets and 31 class-level forgetting tasks with ResNet-18 it drives forget accuracy to within sampling error of the chance level on all six (two at a longer epoch budget), with retain accuracy at or above 97.2% on the 10-class datasets, and step-level logs of a CIFAR-10 run confirm the constraint at every step. On BatchNorm backbones, forgetting learned against frozen normalisation statistics is undone by recomputing them—as concurrent work finds for six of nine prior methods. A variant that keeps the statistics consistent with the weights forgets to chance on every CIFAR-10 class and on MNIST and survives that attack, including when the attacker chooses the recalibration data. We also find that the conventional membership-inference target of 0.5 is the wrong reference point: a retrained model scores 0.69 on CIFAR-10, and between 0.31 and 0.70 across PathMNIST classes.

1 Introduction

Trained models increasingly need to demonstrably *forget* specific data—to honour deletion requests, revoke expired licences, or remove poisoned samples. Retraining without the data does this exactly but is costly (under an hour for a ResNet-18 on CIFAR-10 on one A100, days for production models), so *machine unlearning* (MU) asks how to modify a trained model so that it behaves as if the data had never been seen. The hard part is not erasing the data's influence but doing so *without collateral damage*: what must be erased and what must be kept live in the same weights, so any step that degrades the forgotten data also perturbs everything else.

The mirror image in continual learning. Continual learning (CL) faces the same problem with the sign reversed: learn a new task while protecting old ones. One of its most direct answers is not a penalty but a *constraint on the update*. A-GEM (Chaudhry et al., 2019) projects any update v with $\langle v, g_{\text{old}} \rangle < 0$ onto the half-space $\{u : \langle u, g_{\text{old}} \rangle \geq 0\}$, so a step that would increase old-task loss to first order is never taken. Unlearning lacks exactly this guarantee: most existing methods control retain damage with weighted objectives, saliency masks or alternating updates (§2), which discourage retain-harming steps rather than exclude them. We treat the retain set as CL's "old task" and adopt the half-space constraint as the update rule for unlearning. The duality has been noted before (Kurmanji et al., 2023; Nguyen et al., 2020), and the forget–retain conflict has been targeted by a soft regulariser (Patel & Qiu, 2025)and by projecting updates away from a retain gradient subspace (Hoang et al., 2024); what has not been done, to our knowledge, is

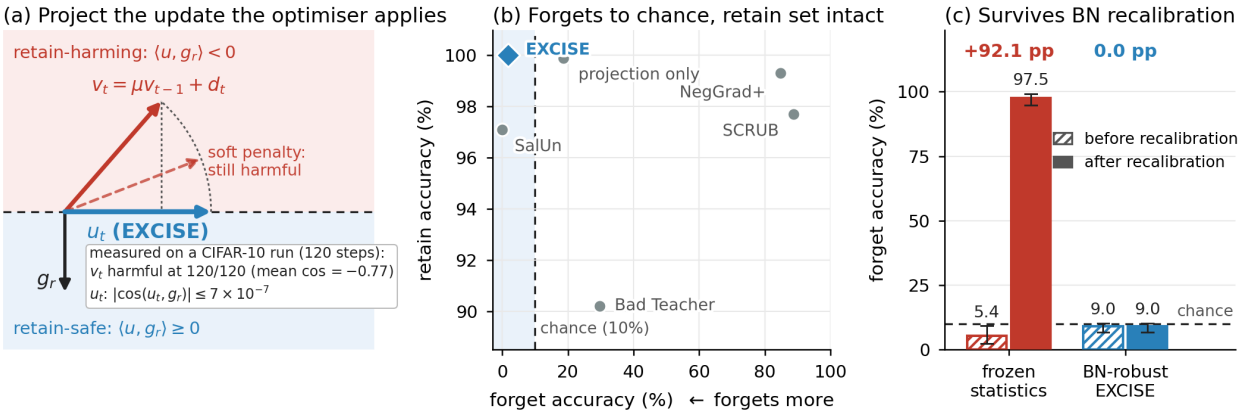


Figure 1: **Excise in one picture. (a)** With momentum, the update the optimiser applies is the accumulated v_t, and in unlearning it points into the retain-harming half-space at every step. EXCISE projects v_t onto the boundary and restores its length, so the applied u_t cannot increase the sampled retain loss to first order (Theorem 1); a soft penalty only tilts the step, which stays harmful (Theorem 2). The boxed numbers are measured (Figure 3). **(b)** On CIFAR-10 class 0, EXCISE is the only method in Table 4 that forgets to chance with the retain set intact. **(c)** With frozen BatchNorm statistics, recomputing them on retained data undoes the forgetting on every CIFAR-10 class; BN-robust EXCISE does not move. Bars are means over the ten classes and whiskers their range (Table 22).

to enforce the half-space constraint against the current retain gradient, at every step, on the vector the optimiser applies.

What it takes. Three design decisions complete the method. *Project the update, not the gradient*: with momentum, the applied vector is the accumulated update, and projecting the gradient certifies nothing about it (Proposition 1). Removing momentum would make the analysis exact but leaves forget accuracy far above chance on five of six datasets (§6.4), so we project the post-momentum update and make the guarantee hold for the optimiser that runs. *Push the forgotten class toward the model's own retain-confusion distribution*, rather than the uniform distribution no trained model produces; at equal test accuracy it forgets further than gradient ascent and slightly further than a uniform target (§4.3). *Stop on explicit tolerances* for retain loss and forget accuracy rather than on an epoch count (§4.3).

Forgetting that survives the attack. A fourth issue came from the experiments. Forget batches contain a single class and would corrupt BatchNorm running statistics, so the method freezes them during unlearning—and the weights then learn to forget *relative to* statistics an attacker can replace: recomputing them on retained data restores forget accuracy from ∼1% to ∼100% without changing a weight (§6.5). The attack reaches beyond us. Concurrent work (Kalani et al., 2026) applies it to nine prior methods and recovers the forgotten class for six of them; of the other three, gradient ascent forgets only by destroying the model (57% retain accuracy), GA+FT does not forget (68% forget accuracy), and SCRUB keeps its forgetting at 88% retain accuracy. Whether a method survives depends less on the method than on how its statistics are handled during unlearning: in Kalani et al. (2026), mixing at least a quarter of retained data into SalUn's unlearning batches removes its recovery, and our own reproductions of SalUn and Bad Teacher, which end every epoch with a pass over retained data that recomputes the statistics, are not recovered at all. BN-robust EXCISE makes survival a property of the method rather than of how it is run: it keeps the statistics consistent with the weights throughout unlearning, forgets to chance on every CIFAR-10 class and on MNIST, survives the attack in every case we tried—including when the attacker chooses the recalibration data—and keeps the per-step guarantee (§6.5). To our knowledge it is the only unlearning method for BatchNorm ResNets whose survival has been verified on every class of a benchmark and against attacker-chosen recalibration data, which we take to make it the state of the art for this setting, pending a like-for-like run of the prior methods under the same base and attack (§7).

Table 1: **Structural comparison of update rules.** ✓ = holds by construction, ∼ = partial or hyperparameter-dependent, ✗ = not provided. Entries are properties of each method's *definition*, not measured quantities; an empirical comparison against Patel & Qiu (2025) is future work (§7). P&Q = Patel & Qiu (2025); PGU = Hoang et al. (2024), whose projection removes the update's component in a retain subspace estimated before unlearning and truncated at an energy threshold, so its protection is approximate and not stated against the current retain gradient. †EXCISE takes an explicit tolerance and honours it across a 29pp range, but only when the stopping rule is evaluated per step: at a 50-batch check granularity, targets from 5% to 30% collapse onto the same operating point (§6.7, Table 16).

Property	GA	SalUn	SCRUB	NG+	P&Q	PGU	Excise
Addresses forget–retain gradient conflict	✗	✗	∼	∼	✓	✓	✓
Conflict handled as a constraint, not a penalty	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	✓	✓
Retain-harming steps are unreachable	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	∼	✓
Per-step retain-safety guarantee	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	∼	✓
Explicit forgetting tolerance	✗	✗	∼	∼	∼	∼	✓†
Guarantee holds for the optimiser actually run	✗	✗	✗	✗	✗	∼	✓

Contributions. **(1)** A constrained formulation of class unlearning (Eq. 2) that assigns each mechanism of the algorithm to the condition it enforces. **(2)** EXCISE: A-GEM projection as the *update rule* of unlearning, applied to the post-momentum update, with clipping before accumulation and magnitude-preserving projection. **(3)** An exact per-step retain-safety theorem for that optimiser, a separation theorem showing that gradient ascent, SCRUB, SalUn and soft conflict penalties admit retain-harming steps, and tests of both theorems on real runs. **(4)** A BatchNorm-recalibration failure mode of EXCISE and a fix that keeps BatchNorm, verified on every CIFAR-10 class, on MNIST and against attacker-chosen recalibration data. We also show that the conventional MIA target of 0.5 is the wrong reference point for class unlearning (§6.6). Table 2 maps every claim to the experiment that tests it.

2 Related Work

Exact unlearning retrains on shards (Bourtoule et al., 2021) or certifies removal for convex models (Guo et al., 2020). *Approximate* methods modify the trained model: gradient ascent and NegGrad+ (Thudi et al., 2022) maximise forget loss, the latter with a weighted retain term; SalUn (Fan et al., 2024) confines random-label updates to a saliency mask; Fisher methods and SSD (Golatkar et al., 2020a; Foster et al., 2024) dampen parameters by estimated importance; Bad Teacher (Chundawat et al., 2023) and SCRUB (Kurmanji et al., 2023) use distillation, SCRUB alternating forget and retain steps. Each balances forgetting against retain damage through a weight, a mask or a schedule, so retain damage is discouraged rather than excluded (Theorem 2). Closest to us are methods that address the forget–retain gradient conflict directly: Patel & Qiu (2025) with a soft regulariser that rewards positive alignment, and Hoang et al. (2024) by stepping orthogonally to a gradient subspace estimated for the retained data. EXCISE instead imposes A-GEM's half-space constraint (Chaudhry et al., 2019) against the current retain gradient at every step, on the post-momentum update the optimiser applies, which is what makes its guarantee exact for the deployed optimiser. Table 1 summarises the structural difference; Appendix A gives the full comparison. On the evaluation side, Kalani et al. (2026) show that recomputing BatchNorm statistics recovers the forgotten class for six of nine prior methods; §6.5 applies the same attack to EXCISE.

3 Problem Formulation

Let f_θ be a trained K-class classifier with weights θ_0, σ the softmax, and $p_\theta(x) = \sigma(f_\theta(x))$. The training set splits into a forget set $\mathcal{D}_f$ and a retain set $\mathcal{D}_r$. We evaluate with test accuracy (TA, held-out data), forget accuracy (FA, on $\mathcal{D}_f$; a fully unlearned model reaches at most the chance level $100/K\%$), retain accuracy (RA, on $\mathcal{D}_r$), and the AUROC of a membership-inference attack (MIA) between forget-class training and

test samples. The *retain-confusion distribution* is the base model's average prediction on retained data,

$$p_r = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{D}_r|} \sum_{x \in \mathcal{D}_r} \sigma(f_{\theta_0}(x)), \tag{1}$$

and we pose unlearning as a constrained search: find

$$\theta^\star \in \big\{\theta : \ \mathrm{FA}(\theta; \mathcal{D}_f) \le \tau_F, \ \ \mathrm{CE}(\theta; \mathcal{D}_r) \le \alpha \, \mathrm{CE}(\theta_0; \mathcal{D}_r), \ \ \|\theta - \theta_0\| \le R\big\}, \tag{2}$$

where τ_F is a forget-accuracy target (the chance level by default), $\alpha \ge 1$ a tolerance on the retain loss, and R a trust radius. The first two conditions say what it means to have forgotten without damage; the third asks for a solution near the trained model, and the search path supplies it. EXCISE starts at θ_0, descends the forget objective $\mathcal{L}_\mathrm{f} = \mathbb{E}_{x_f}[\mathrm{KL}(p_\theta(x_f) \| p_r)]$ along directions that do not increase the retain objective $\mathcal{L}_\mathrm{r} = \mathbb{E}_{(x,y)}[\mathrm{CE}(f_\theta(x), y)] + \beta \, \mathcal{L}_\mathrm{KD}$ to first order, where β weights a distillation anchor, and returns the first point that meets the forget target. $\mathcal{L}_\mathrm{f}$ supplies the direction, not the destination: driving it to its minimum over-forgets (Appendix J). Retain safety is imposed at two levels. At every step the projection of §4.1 keeps the applied update in $\{u : \langle u, g_\mathrm{r} \rangle \ge 0\}$, so the sampled retain objective cannot increase to first order (Theorem 1); on the full retain set, the stopping rule ends the search if the retain cross-entropy exceeds its tolerance. The first level is a hard constraint rather than a penalty because a Lagrangian relaxation would turn it back into the soft treatment whose feasible set still contains retain-harming steps (Theorem 2(iv)). The trust region needs no mechanism of its own: every step has length at most $\eta c/(1-\mu)$ (Theorem 1), so N steps stay within $R = N\eta c/(1-\mu)$. Table 9 (Appendix B) maps each condition to its mechanism.

4 The Excise Algorithm

Algorithm 1 gives the update. Each step computes a retain gradient g_r on a retain mini-batch (cross-entropy plus the distillation anchor) and a forget gradient g_f on a forget mini-batch.

4.1 Projection onto the Retain-Safe Half-Space

When a candidate update v satisfies $\langle v, g_\mathrm{r} \rangle < 0$, moving along it would increase the retain loss to first order, and we replace it by its projection

$$\Pi_{g_\mathrm{r}}(v) = v - \frac{\langle v, g_\mathrm{r} \rangle}{\|g_\mathrm{r}\|^2} \, g_\mathrm{r}, \qquad \langle \Pi_{g_\mathrm{r}}(v), g_\mathrm{r} \rangle = 0. \tag{3}$$

This is A-GEM's operator: the minimum-norm correction that restores feasibility, at the cost of one extra backward pass. What changes is its role. In A-GEM it occasionally corrects a process whose objective already points the right way; in unlearning, erasing a class and keeping the rest are directly opposed, and the projection fires at 96–100% of steps in every EXCISE run we logged (§6.3). It becomes the optimiser's defining step rather than a safeguard, which has three consequences for how it must be applied.

4.2 Which Vector to Project

(i) Project the update, not the gradient. EXCISE uses SGD with momentum μ, weight decay and clipping c. The vector applied to the weights is the accumulated update, so we accumulate first and project afterwards (Algorithm 1, lines 10–15); projecting g_f instead leaves the applied update unconstrained (Proposition 1, Figure 2). *(ii) Clip before accumulating.* Clipping the per-step ingredient keeps momentum's $1/(1-\mu)$ amplification and gives $\|v_t\| \le c/(1-\mu)$; clipping the final update would cap it at c, the step size of the momentum-free update, which leaves forget accuracy far above chance on five of six datasets (§6.4, Proposition 2). Raw forget gradients are $\sim$100$\times$ the clip threshold, so clipping is always active and that cap would always bind. *(iii) Preserve magnitude.* Projection shrinks the update by $\sin\vartheta$, which vanishes when forget and retain gradients are nearly opposed (on the logged CIFAR-10 run it falls to 0.37), so we rescale the projected update to the pre-projection norm; $\langle u_t, g_\mathrm{r} \rangle = 0$ is unaffected.

Algorithm 1 EXCISE unlearning (projected-momentum update)

Require: Trained model θ, forget set $\mathcal{D}_f$, retain set $\mathcal{D}_r$; lr η, momentum μ, clip c, weight decay λ_{wd}; targets τ_F, α; check interval m
Ensure: Unlearned model θ^*

$\theta_{\text{orig}} \leftarrow \text{freeze}(\text{copy}(\theta))$; set all BatchNorm layers to `eval` mode
$p_r \leftarrow \frac{1}{|\mathcal{D}_r|} \sum_{x \in \mathcal{D}_r} \sigma(\theta_{\text{orig}}(x))$
$L_0 \leftarrow \text{CE}(\theta, \mathcal{D}_r)$; $v \leftarrow 0$
for epoch $= 1$ to T **do**
  for (x_f, y_f) in $\mathcal{D}_f$ **do**
    Sample (x_r, y_r) from $\mathcal{D}_r$
    $g_{\text{r}} \leftarrow \nabla_\theta[\text{CE}(f_\theta(x_r), y_r) + \beta \mathcal{L}_{\text{KD}}]$
    $g_{\text{f}} \leftarrow \nabla_\theta \mathcal{L}_{\text{f}}(\theta; x_f)$
    $d \leftarrow \text{clip}_c\big(g_{\text{f}} + \lambda_{\text{wd}}\theta\big)$ *// clip BEFORE accumulation*
    $v \leftarrow \mu v + d$ *// momentum*
    if $\langle v, g_{\text{r}} \rangle < 0$ **then**
      $u \leftarrow v - \frac{\langle v, g_{\text{r}} \rangle}{\|g_{\text{r}}\|^2} g_{\text{r}}$; $u \leftarrow u \, \|v\| / \|u\|$ *// project the update, rescale*
    else
      $u \leftarrow v$
    end if
    $\theta \leftarrow \theta - \eta u$
    if every m steps: $\text{FA}(\theta, \mathcal{D}_f) \leq \tau_F$ **then**
      return θ *// forget target met*
    end if
  end for
  if $\text{CE}(\theta, \mathcal{D}_r) > \alpha L_0$ **then**
    return θ *// retain tolerance exceeded*
  end if
end for
return $\theta^* \leftarrow \theta$

4.3 Forget Objective, Stopping, and Normalisation

The `kl_retain` objective drives forget-set predictions toward the retain-confusion distribution rather than the uniform one,

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{KL-R}} = \text{KL}(\log \sigma(f_\theta(x_f)) \,\|\, p_r)\,. \tag{4}$$

Under the projected-momentum optimiser it forgets further than gradient ascent and slightly further than a uniform target at equal test accuracy (FA 2.1% against 8.2% and 3.9%, at TA 86.1, 86.4 and 86.4%; CIFAR-10 class 0, one seed) and is within noise of a uniform target on MIA, so we claim a better forget *direction*, not a closer imitation of a retrained model (Appendix B).

Dual stopping. Unlearning halts if the retain cross-entropy, measured on the full retain set after each epoch, exceeds α times its initial value, and completes when FA reaches the target τ_F—by default the chance level $100/K\%$—checked every $m = 50$ steps within epochs, because FA can fall by tens of points inside one.

BatchNorm. Class-homogeneous forget batches would corrupt BatchNorm running statistics, so EXCISE freezes them. The weights then learn to forget relative to those frozen statistics; §6.5 shows that this forgetting does not survive recomputing them, and BN-robust EXCISE recomputes them from retained data before every step instead (§6.5). A distillation anchor to the frozen base model enters the retain objective; removing it changes retain accuracy by only 0.04pp on CIFAR-10 (§6.3), so we keep it as a safeguard rather than claim it as load-bearing.

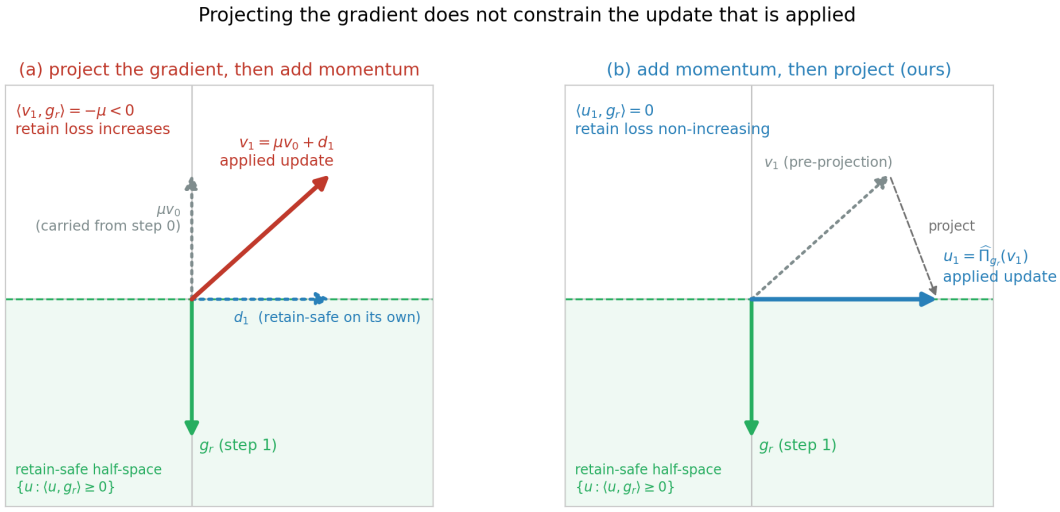


Figure 2: **Why the projection is applied to the update, not the gradient** (Proposition 1). Both panels show step 1, whose constraint is g_r; the retain-safe half-space is shaded. **(a)** Each ingredient is individually retain-safe—d_1 lies on the boundary, and μv_0 was certified against step 0's constraint—yet their sum, the vector actually applied, lies in the harming half-space with $\langle v_1, g_r \rangle = -\mu$. The violation grows with μ. **(b)** Projecting the accumulated update instead returns it to the boundary, so the certificate is issued against the constraint in force where the step is taken.

5 Theoretical Guarantees

Theorem 1 (Exact per-step retain safety under momentum)**.** *Let $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_r$, the retain objective $\mathcal{L}_r$ (cross-entropy plus $\beta\mathcal{L}_{KD}$) evaluated on the sampled retain mini-batch, be L-smooth, and let $g_r = \nabla_\theta \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_r(\theta_t)$. Let* Excise *run the update of Algorithm 1: $\|d_t\| \le c$ by clipping, $v_t = \mu v_{t-1} + d_t$ with $v_{-1} = 0$ and $\mu \in [0, 1)$, $u_t = \Pi_{g_r}(v_t)\,\|v_t\|/\|\Pi_{g_r}(v_t)\|$ when $\langle v_t, g_r \rangle < 0$ (and $u_t = 0$ if $\Pi_{g_r}(v_t) = 0$) and $u_t = v_t$ otherwise, and $\theta_{t+1} = \theta_t - \eta u_t$. Then, exactly and with no assumption on g_f or on its alignment with g_r,*

$$\langle u_t, g_r \rangle \ge 0, \qquad \|u_t\| \le \|v_t\| \le \frac{c}{1-\mu}, \qquad \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_r(\theta_{t+1}) \le \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_r(\theta_t) + \tfrac{1}{2} L \eta^2 \Big(\frac{c}{1-\mu}\Big)^2. \tag{5}$$

Proof sketch. The first claim is immediate: if $\langle v_t, g_r \rangle \ge 0$ then $u_t = v_t$; otherwise $\langle \Pi_{g_r}(v_t), g_r \rangle = 0$ identically, and rescaling by a positive scalar preserves this. For the second, Π_{g_r} is the orthogonal projection onto $\{u : \langle u, g_r \rangle = 0\}$, so the rescaling restores $\|u_t\| = \|v_t\|$ unless the projection vanishes; unrolling the buffer gives $v_t = \sum_{k=0}^{t} \mu^{t-k} d_k$, hence $\|v_t\| \le c \sum_{j=0}^{t} \mu^j < c/(1-\mu)$. The third follows from L-smoothness, $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_r(\theta_{t+1}) \le \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_r(\theta_t) - \eta \langle u_t, g_r \rangle + \frac{1}{2} L \eta^2 \|u_t\|^2$, where the first-order term is non-positive by claim one and $\|u_t\|$ is bounded by claim two. The full proof, together with the three supporting lemmas, is given in Appendix D (Theorem 3). □

The first-order change in the sampled retain loss is non-positive at every step, and, unlike guarantees stated for momentum-free surrogates, the analysed u_t is the vector the code applies. The bound concerns the sampled mini-batch objective, not the population retain loss (§7). Section 6.3 tests the theorem on a logged run.

Theorem 2 (Per-step separation)**.** *For any model θ_0 with retain gradient g_r: **(i)** GA's update $+\eta g_f$ strictly increases retain loss to first order whenever $\langle g_f, g_r \rangle > 0$; **(ii)** SCRUB's $-g_f + \lambda g_r$ can have $\langle \cdot, g_r \rangle < 0$ for any fixed λ; **(iii)** SalUn's masked random-label gradient has unconstrained sign with respect to g_r; **(iv)** a soft conflict regulariser that adds $\rho\,\phi(\langle g, g_r \rangle)$ with ϕ decreasing—the approach of the closest prior work (Patel & Qiu, 2025)—shifts the optimum toward positive alignment but leaves the feasible set unrestricted: for any finite ρ, a sufficiently large forget-loss reduction still makes a step with $\langle g, g_r \rangle < 0$ preferable. Among these*

Table 2: **Each claim and the experiment that tests it.**

Claim	Test	Outcome
Forgets to chance, retain set intact	31 tasks, six datasets (Table 3)	Chance on all six, two at 60 epochs; RA $\geq 97.2\%$ on the 10-class datasets
Only EXCISE does both on CIFAR-10	Four baselines, projection only (Table 4)	FA 1.87% at RA 100%; SalUn loses 2.9pp RA, the rest stop at FA $\geq 18.7\%$
Theorem 1 holds for the optimiser that runs	Step-level audit (Figure 3)	120/120 steps conflict before projection; $\lvert\cos\rvert \leq 7.4 \times 10^{-7}$ after; $\lVert u_t \rVert \leq 9.16 < 10$
Soft corrections leave harm reachable (Thm. 2)	Projection strength s, equal compute (§6.3)	RA rises from 52.5 to 99.98% as $s \to 1$; every $s < 1$ leaves conflict in the applied step
The projection protects the retain set	Ablation, equal compute (§6.3)	Without it RA is 52.6%; alone it keeps RA 99.9% but stops at FA 18.7%
The guarantee must cover momentum	$\mu = 0$ ablation (Table 5)	With $\mu = 0$, FA stays far above chance on five of six datasets
Frozen statistics make forgetting reversible	Recalibration attack (Table 6)	Frozen EXCISE: FA $1.4 \to 99.7\%$; base model and our baselines: $\Delta F \leq 0$
BN-robust EXCISE survives it	Ten classes, MNIST, attacker's data (Figures 1c, 4)	$\lvert\Delta F\rvert \leq 0.06$pp on every CIFAR-10 class, +0.09pp on MNIST; attacker's data: -1.2 to -1.0pp
0.5 is the wrong MIA target	Retrained references (Table 8)	References score 0.69 (CIFAR-10) and 0.31–0.70 (PathMNIST); rankings reverse
p_r is a better direction than uniform	Forget objectives, equal TA (§4.3)	FA 2.1% against 3.9% (uniform) and 8.2% (GA); one seed

update rules, only EXCISE's guarantees $\langle u_t, g_r \rangle \geq 0$ at every step, because only a projection makes such steps unreachable rather than merely costly.

6 Experiments

6.1 Setup

We forget one class at a time on six benchmarks that vary class count, examples per class and domain: CIFAR-10 and CIFAR-100 (Krizhevsky, 2009), MNIST (LeCun et al., 1998), SVHN (Netzer et al., 2011), STL-10 (Coates et al., 2011) and PathMNIST (Yang et al., 2023). We forget every class of MNIST and PathMNIST, classes $10, 20, \ldots, 90$ of CIFAR-100, and class 0 of CIFAR-10, SVHN and STL-10 over three seeds: 31 tasks and 75 runs. All models are ResNet-18 (He et al., 2016). SalUn, SCRUB, Bad Teacher and NegGrad+ are re-run on our stack, and a model retrained without the forget class serves as the reference. MIA is the mean AUROC of a loss and a confidence attack. Hyperparameters are fixed per dataset and released as configuration files (Appendix I); Appendix F gives the full protocol. Table 2 lists every claim of §1 with the experiment that tests it; the subsections follow its order.

6.2 Main Results

At its epoch cap EXCISE drives FA to or below the chance level on four of six datasets with RA $\geq 97.2\%$ (CIFAR-100: 92.2%), and the mean over seeds is below chance for every one of the ten MNIST and nine PathMNIST classes (one of the 30 MNIST runs ends at 10.2%, within sampling error) (Table 3, Appendix H). The two shortfalls are budget-limited: STL-10 gets ∼60 optimiser steps at its 15-epoch cap against ∼600 for CIFAR-10 at the same cap, and at 60 epochs (per-step check, 1% target) STL-10 reaches 1.73% (9.2% in a single run at its default 10% target) and CIFAR-100 1.27%—against a 1% chance level, within one standard error of a 500-image forget set—so all six datasets reach chance. On CIFAR-10 (Table 4, Figure 1b), EXCISE is the only method in the table that both forgets to chance and leaves retain accuracy untouched: SalUn forgets fully but costs 2.9pp of retain accuracy, Bad Teacher stops at 29.7% while damaging the model, and SCRUB and NegGrad+ keep the model intact by barely forgetting. The projection alone does not unlearn:

Table 3: **Cross-dataset results.** Mean ± sample std over classes × seeds (3 seeds per task; one seed per class for CIFAR-100). #T = number of forgetting tasks. Chance = $100/K\%$ is the level a fully unlearned model must reach. The upper block uses each dataset's epoch cap (12–20 epochs, Appendix I), which penalises datasets with few images per class, since the binding resource is optimiser steps rather than epochs. The lower block re-runs the two datasets that fall short at 60 epochs (4× and 3× their caps), with a per-step check and a 1% forget target, on the same seeds and classes; *marks the STL-10 row it supersedes (§F.2).

Dataset	#T	Chance	TA	FA↓	RA	MIA
CIFAR-10	1	10.0%	86.13 ± 0.02	$\mathbf{1.87} \pm 0.25$	100.00 ± 0.00	0.529 ± 0.001
MNIST	10	10.0%	90.00 ± 0.64	$\mathbf{6.17} \pm 2.81$	99.49 ± 0.04	0.497 ± 0.009
SVHN	1	10.0%	89.69 ± 0.02	$\mathbf{5.75} \pm 0.17$	97.26 ± 0.01	0.525 ± 0.001
STL-10*	1	10.0%	92.84 ± 0.02	75.67 ± 1.70	99.38 ± 0.10	0.466 ± 0.005
PathMNIST	9	11.1%	80.96 ± 5.39	$\mathbf{5.82} \pm 3.42$	98.88 ± 0.31	0.483 ± 0.084
CIFAR-100	9	1.0%	76.17 ± 0.86	4.07 ± 5.51	92.19 ± 0.84	0.500 ± 0.037
Extended budget (60 epochs, per-step check, 1% forget target; same seeds and classes)						
STL-10	1	10.0%	85.15 ± 0.06	$\mathbf{1.73} \pm 0.95$	98.87 ± 0.05	0.488 ± 0.008
CIFAR-100	9	1.0%	75.50 ± 0.68	$\mathbf{1.27} \pm 0.39$	91.32 ± 0.94	0.490 ± 0.043

Table 4: **CIFAR-10 class-0 forgetting.** EXCISE is a 3-seed mean ± std. Methods with FA > 80% attain MIA ≈ 0.5 trivially, by barely changing the model. †Our reproduction; ‡our reproduction with unified MIA. §A-GEM projection applied to plain gradient ascent, with EXCISE's KD anchor and retain-confusion target removed: the direct projected-gradient baseline, isolating what the projection alone achieves. ¶The retrained reference of §6.6; its TA and RA were not logged, and its MIA, from the same two attacks, is 0.565, not 0.5.

Method	TA	FA↓	RA	MIA
Retrain (reference)¶	—	0.0	—	0.565
SalUn†	84.0	0.0	97.1	0.497
Bad Teacher‡	82.0	29.7	90.2	0.499
SCRUB‡	93.3	88.8	97.7	0.515
NegGrad+‡	94.2	84.8	99.3	0.525
Projection-only§	86.23	18.66	99.90	0.511
Excise	**86.13** ± .02	**1.87** ± .25	**100.00** ± .00	**0.529** ± .001

applied to plain gradient ascent it preserves the retain set but stalls at 18.66%, so the projection supplies retain safety and the `kl_retain` objective supplies the forgetting.

6.3 The Guarantees, Measured

Theorem 1 on a real run. We log every step of a CIFAR-10 run (class 0, 120 steps; Figure 3, Appendix F.4). The accumulated update conflicts with the retain gradient at all 120 steps (mean $\cos(v_t, g_r) = -0.77$), so the projection is the optimiser's defining step rather than a safeguard. After projection the alignment is zero to float32 precision ($|\cos(u_t, g_r)| \leq 7.4 \times 10^{-7}$), and $\|u_t\|$ peaks at 9.16 against the bound $c/(1-\mu) = 10$.

Theorem 2(iv): soft against hard. To test the separation without reimplementing another method, we vary our own projection between a soft correction and the hard constraint: at conflicting steps $u = v - s\,\frac{\langle v, g_r\rangle}{\|g_r\|^2} g_r$, so $\langle u, g_r\rangle = (1-s)\langle v, g_r\rangle < 0$ for every $s < 1$. At equal compute with stopping disabled every setting forgets completely (FA 0.0%), so the settings differ only in collateral damage: RA is 52.5, 81.4, 92.8, 98.2 and 99.98% for $s = 0, 0.25, 0.5, 0.75, 1$ (Appendix F.9). The curve is gradual—$s = 0.75$ already keeps 98.2%—so the case for $s = 1$ is that it is the only setting with a guarantee, not that the last 1.8pp is large.

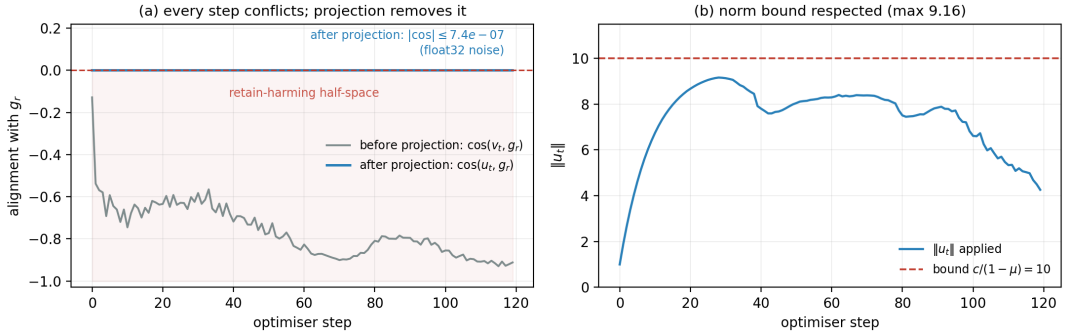


Figure 3: **Theorem 1 audited on a real run** (CIFAR-10 class 0, 120 steps). **(a)** Alignment with the retain gradient, normalised to $\cos(\cdot, g_r)$. Before projection every step lies in the retain-harming half-space (mean -0.77); after projection the alignment is indistinguishable from zero ($|\cos| \leq 7.4 \times 10^{-7}$, the float32 accumulation scale). **(b)** The applied update never exceeds the bound $c/(1-\mu) = 10$ of Eq. 5, peaking at 9.16—tight, but respected.

Table 5: **Momentum ablation.** Removing momentum to simplify the analysis leaves forget accuracy far above chance on five of six datasets; on STL-10 projected momentum also falls short at this budget (Table 3). High RA with high FA indicates the model barely changed. Same configs, seeds, and stopping rules throughout.

		$\mu = 0$ (analysis-friendly)		Projected momentum (ours)	
Dataset	**Chance**	**FA↓**	**RA**	**FA↓**	**RA**
CIFAR-10	10.0%	5.8	100.0	1.9	100.0
MNIST	10.0%	95.9	99.5	6.2	99.5
SVHN	10.0%	61.9	97.4	5.8	97.3
STL-10	10.0%	99.7	99.4	75.7	99.4
PathMNIST	11.1%	16.4	99.0	5.8	98.9
CIFAR-100	1.0%	73.7	94.1	4.1	92.2

The projection is what protects the retain set. At equal compute with stopping disabled, removing the projection collapses the model (TA 44.4% and RA 52.6%, against 85.7% and 99.98% with it), removing the distillation anchor changes RA by 0.04pp, and the projection on its own keeps RA at 99.9% but stalls at FA 18.7% (Tables 4 and 14). With stopping enabled every variant halts after one epoch and the projection looks costless, which is why we report both modes.

6.4 Momentum Is Not Incidental

Removing momentum is the most direct route to an exact guarantee, since the applied update then equals the projected gradient. Table 5 shows the cost: with $\mu = 0$ and everything else fixed, forget accuracy stays far above chance on five of six datasets (FA 95.9% on MNIST, 99.7% on STL-10, 73.7% on CIFAR-100), and RA stays high only because the model barely moves. STL-10 does not forget at this budget with momentum either (75.7%), so the comparison rests on the other four: without momentum all four stay far above chance; with it, three reach chance and CIFAR-100 ends at 4.1%. A guarantee stated for the momentum-free update would be exact and would describe a method that does not unlearn. The dependence is not ours alone: every update rule we tested loses forgetting without momentum, but the KL objectives lose 70–79pp against 12–15pp for gradient ascent (with or without projection; means over MNIST and SVHN), consistent with a bounded objective needing momentum's $1/(1-\mu)$ amplification (Appendix F.3).

Table 6: **BatchNorm recalibration** (CIFAR-10, class 0), using `update_bn` on the retain set: BatchNorm buffers are reset and recomputed, no weight is touched. Our reproductions of the baselines and the un-unlearned base model are unaffected ($\Delta F \leq 0$); EXCISE with a BatchNorm backbone loses essentially all of its forgetting. The two backbones without running statistics are outside the operator's reach by construction. NegGrad+ is omitted: no checkpoint for it was available.

Configuration	pre-F	post-F	$\boldsymbol{\Delta F}$	pre-TA	post-TA
Base model (no unlearning)	100.0	99.8	−0.2	95.5	92.9
SalUn	0.0	0.0	+0.0	84.7	84.4
Bad Teacher	28.7	28.4	−0.3	81.5	84.0
SCRUB	89.3	85.7	−3.6	93.5	93.2
EXCISE (BatchNorm, frozen)	1.4	99.7	**+98.4**	86.1	92.9
EXCISE (GroupNorm)	4.9	4.9	**0.0**	84.2	84.2
EXCISE (ViT-B/16, LayerNorm)	9.6	9.6	**0.0**	87.0	87.0

Table 7: **BN-robust Excise under BatchNorm recalibration** (CIFAR-10, class 0, seeds $\{42, 123, 456\}$; `update_bn` on the retain set, as in Table 6). Every row shares the 93.97% base except GroupNorm, which needs its own. The un-unlearned base is the control: recalibrating it changes nothing. *Naive* stopping reads FA under the in-loop statistics, *calibrated* stopping under the statistics that ship. Time is wall-clock per run on one GPU.

Configuration	base TA	pre-F	post-F	$\boldsymbol{\Delta F}$	TA	RA	epochs	min
Base model (no unlearning)	93.97	99.80	99.82	+0.0	93.97	—	—	—
EXCISE (BatchNorm, frozen)	93.97	8.51 ± 0.30	99.12 ± 0.09	**+90.6**	85.20	97.34	2	1.9
EXCISE (GroupNorm)	91.89	5.91 ± 0.09	n/a	n/a	83.13	98.92	3	2.5
BN-robust, naive stopping	93.97	11.43 ± 1.90	11.44 ± 1.87	**0.0**	84.42	95.46	11–13	9.8
BN-robust, calibrated stopping	93.97	9.19 ± 0.08	9.18 ± 0.07	**0.0**	84.30	95.59	13	13.3

6.5 BatchNorm: the Attack, and a Fix That Keeps BatchNorm

The attack. `update_bn` resets every BatchNorm buffer and recomputes the statistics on the retain set without touching a weight; we verify that every learnable parameter is bit-identical afterwards. Table 6 shows that recalibration leaves the un-unlearned base model and every baseline we reproduced unaffected, but undoes EXCISE with frozen statistics completely: forget accuracy returns from 1.4% to 99.7% and test accuracy to 92.9%, the value recalibration gives the base model itself. Because the statistics are frozen, the weights learn to forget against statistics an attacker can replace. Our baseline reproductions survive because each ends every epoch with a pass over retained data in train mode, which recomputes the statistics. Under their reference implementations, Kalani et al. (2026) recover six of nine prior methods, and find SalUn's recovery disappears once at least a quarter of each unlearning batch is retained data. GroupNorm and a ViT's LayerNorm keep no running statistics and are outside the attack's reach by construction (Tables 12 and 13), but that is a change of architecture, not robustness.

BN-robust Excise. We keep BatchNorm and stop the statistics going stale. Before every step they are recomputed on 512 retain images with the attacker's own operator, after the last step on the whole retain set, and the stopping rule reads forget accuracy under the statistics that will ship, falling back to the best epoch if the target is not met (Figure 7, Appendix F.6). The update rule is unchanged, so Theorem 1 holds at every step for the retain objective under the statistics in force during that step; the recalibration between steps is not a gradient step, and the theorem does not bound its effect. Table 7 gives the result on a separate base model (the checkpoints behind Table 6 were no longer available): with frozen statistics the attack returns forget accuracy to 99.1%, while BN-robust EXCISE forgets to 9.2% and stays at 9.2%. It holds on all ten CIFAR-10 classes (6.7–10.2% after the attack, all within three standard errors of chance), on MNIST (3.9%, where frozen statistics recover to 99.97%), and when the attacker recalibrates on the full

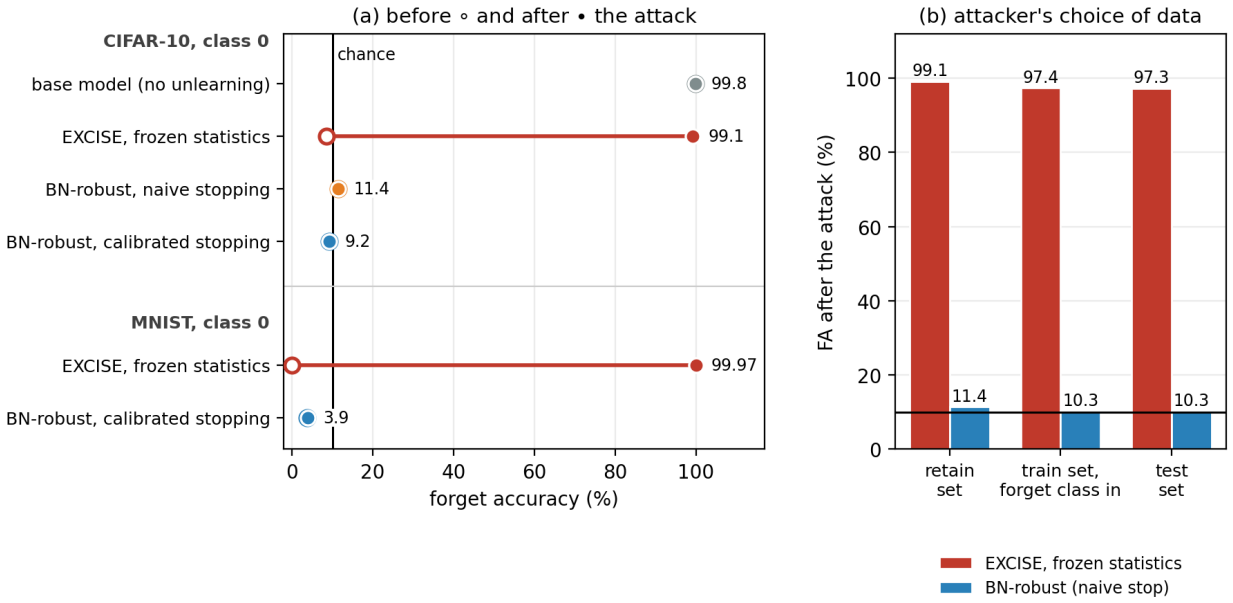


Figure 4: **BN-robust survives the recalibration attack.** (a) Forget accuracy before (open) and after (filled) `update_bn` on the retain set, class 0, means over three seeds; on MNIST the frozen configuration's forgetting is undone completely. (b) Forget accuracy after the attack when the attacker recalibrates on the retain set, the full training set (forget class included), or the test set (CIFAR-10 class 0, three seeds; BN-robust with naive stopping).

training set or the test set instead (tested on the naive-stopping checkpoints, whose FA moves by −1.2 to −1.0pp) (Figure 4, Appendix F.6). It costs about seven times the compute and 1.8pp of retain accuracy, mostly because forgetting that must happen in the weights takes ∼13 epochs instead of 2.

6.6 Membership Inference Needs a Retrained Reference

MIA is usually read against 0.5: an attacker should not be able to tell forget-class training samples from forget-class test samples. We test that target against models retrained without the forget class, which trained on neither group (Table 8; Appendix F.12 adds three attacks). On CIFAR-10 the reference scores 0.694 on the loss attack, with a true-positive rate of 12.5% at 1% false positives, while the base model, which memorised every member, scores 0.483: the attack reads a difference in difficulty between the train and test splits, not membership. Across four PathMNIST classes the reference ranges from 0.306 to 0.704, so no single constant is the right target. Read against 0.5, EXCISE looks the worst of the four methods on CIFAR-10 and SalUn the best; read against the reference, the order reverses. SalUn's 0.500 is also degenerate: its true-positive rate is zero at every threshold, the signature of a constant score. On three of the four PathMNIST classes EXCISE sits far from its own reference (mean gap 0.22–0.36 over four attacks), so we claim the protocol finding, not that EXCISE matches retrained models in general.

6.7 Further Analyses

The appendices report the remaining experiments in full. *Transformer:* on ViT-B/16 forgetting transfers on CIFAR-10, with FA 9.71% and RA 97.55%, but not on CIFAR-100 within its 20-epoch cap, where FA ends between 4.0% and 82.0% across nine classes against a 1% chance level (Appendix F.7). *Tolerances:* the retain budget is non-binding, and the forget target is a usable knob over a 29pp range once it is checked at every step (Appendix F.10). *Distance to a retrained model:* EXCISE is closest in feature space (Fréchet distance 13 against 153–495 for the baselines) and SalUn in output space (Appendix F.11). *Stopping point:* divergence to a retrained model is U-shaped along the trajectory with its minimum above chance, and MIA

Table 8: **Loss-attack MIA against a retrained reference** (CIFAR-10, class 0). Members are the 5000 forget-class training images, non-members the 1000 forget-class test images; TPR is at 1% FPR. Appendix F.12 gives three further attacks and four PathMNIST classes.

Model	FA	AUROC	TPR	$\lvert\text{AUROC} - 0.5\rvert$	$\lvert\text{AUROC} - \text{ref}\rvert$
Retrained (reference)	0.0	0.694	12.5%	0.194	—
Base (no unlearning)	100.0	0.483	0.0%	0.017	0.211
SalUn	0.0	0.500	0.0%	**0.000**	0.194
Bad Teacher	24.8	0.485	0.2%	0.015	0.209
SCRUB	89.5	0.477	0.4%	0.023	0.217
Excise	2.0	0.693	1.4%	0.193	**0.001**

passes through 0.5 rather than converging to it (Appendices F.13 and F.14). *Sequential unlearning:* over three classes TA falls from 86.1% to 69.1% and RA from 100% to 80.7%, no more than the forgotten classes themselves account for (§7).

7 Limitations

The compute a dataset needs cannot be predicted in advance: the binding resource is optimiser steps, and STL-10 and CIFAR-100 needed 60 epochs rather than 15 and 20; ViT-B/16 on CIFAR-100 does not reach chance within its 20-epoch cap. Sample-level forgetting works only crudely, because the retain-confusion target degenerates to uniform when every class remains in the retain set. The guarantee bounds the sampled mini-batch retain objective, not the population loss, and holds to float32 precision; under BN-robust Excise it holds per step under that step's statistics and does not cover the recalibration between steps. Our separation from soft conflict-resolution methods (Patel & Qiu, 2025) is structural; we have not run that method on our stack. BN-robust Excise costs about seven times the compute, was evaluated on two datasets, and defends only the normalisation statistics, not weight-level attacks such as fine-tuning recovery; its comparison with prior methods rests on the evaluations of Kalani et al. (2026) and on our own reproductions, and a like-for-like run of those methods under the same base and attack remains to be done. In sequential unlearning the retained classes are not damaged cumulatively, but earlier-forgotten classes partly return: after three classes RA is 80.7%, above the 77.8% that fully forgotten classes would allow, so they average at least 13% training accuracy, above chance. Excise gives no differential-privacy guarantee. Appendix G discusses each point.

8 Conclusion

Unlearning is the dual of continual learning, and one of continual learning's most direct tools, a hard constraint on the update, carries over. For that constraint to mean anything it must be stated for the update the optimiser applies: projecting the post-momentum update makes Theorem 1 exact for the deployed optimiser, while the analysis-friendly alternative leaves forget accuracy far above chance on five of six datasets. Across six datasets and 31 forgetting tasks Excise reaches the chance level on all six (two at a longer budget) with retain accuracy at or above 97.2% on the 10-class datasets, and step-level logs of a CIFAR-10 run confirm the constraint at every step. On BatchNorm backbones, keeping the normalisation statistics consistent with the weights throughout unlearning makes that forgetting survive recalibration, on every CIFAR-10 class and on MNIST. The duality is also a design space: many continual-learning techniques that protect old-task knowledge suggest unlearning counterparts that protect retained knowledge during erasure. More broadly, when an optimiser detail is chosen for analytical convenience, it should be checked against the behaviour it was meant to explain.

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A Related Work and Positioning in Full

Approximate unlearning methods occupy different points on the privacy–utility frontier, and the retain side is where they differ most. **Gradient ascent** (Thudi et al., 2022) maximises forget-set loss with no mechanism protecting retain accuracy (Theorem 2(i)). **SalUn** (Fan et al., 2024) confines random-label updates to a saliency mask—effective in practice, but with no formal retain guarantee and no control over how much is forgotten. **SCRUB** (Kurmanji et al., 2023) alternates forget and retain steps balanced by a weight λ, so the balance is tuned rather than enforced; in our reproduction it preserves retain accuracy (97.7%) by barely forgetting at all (forget accuracy 88.8%, Table 4). **NegGrad+** (Thudi et al., 2022) adds a retain-loss term as a weighted sum, again without a guarantee that retain loss is controlled. Closest to us, Patel & Qiu (2025) diagnose the same forget–retain gradient conflict but resolve it with a soft regulariser that rewards positive alignment. A fuller treatment, including exact unlearning and distillation-based methods, follows the table.

The distinction we draw is structural rather than numerical, so Table 1 compares properties of each method's *definition* —checkable against the published update rule, without relying on our reimplementation of it. A soft penalty biases the optimiser toward retain-safe steps but leaves harmful steps feasible: for any finite penalty weight, a sufficiently large forget-loss reduction still makes a retain-harming step preferable. A projection removes those steps from the feasible set altogether (Theorem 2(iv)). The final row is the one we would emphasise, and the one §6.4 makes concrete: a guarantee proved for a momentum-free surrogate says nothing about a run that uses momentum.

Figure 1 places the method against the alternatives on both what it achieves and what it guarantees.

Exact unlearning. SISA (Bourtoule et al., 2021) partitions data into shards so that removal requires retraining only the affected shard; the per-deletion cost approaches full retraining as shard count grows. Certified removal (Guo et al., 2020) gives exact guarantees for convex models but does not extend to deep networks.

Gradient-based approximate unlearning. GA (Thudi et al., 2022) maximises forget-set loss, with no mechanism to prevent the same direction from degrading retain performance. Amnesiac unlearning (Graves et al., 2021) subtracts cached per-sample updates, requiring $O(T|\mathcal{D}_f|)$ storage. NegGrad+ optimises $-\mathcal{L}_\mathrm{f} + \lambda\mathcal{L}_\mathrm{r}$ directly, which is the Lagrangian relaxation of Eq. 2 rather than a solution to it: the retain term shifts the optimum without bounding any single step, so the weighted sum is exactly the soft treatment Theorem 2(iv) separates us from.

Saliency and Fisher methods. SalUn (Fan et al., 2024) applies random-label updates inside a top-50% saliency mask: strong empirically (FA = 0% on CIFAR-10) but with no formal retain guarantee and no control over the degree of forgetting. Fisher-based methods (Golatkar et al., 2020a;b) and SSD (Foster et al., 2024) weight parameters by estimated importance, requiring Hessian approximations that scale poorly.

Knowledge distillation. Bad Teacher (Chundawat et al., 2023) uses competent/incompetent teachers. SCRUB (Kurmanji et al., 2023) is closest in motivation—both draw on CL intuitions and use KD to anchor retain behaviour—but differs algorithmically: SCRUB alternates forget and retain steps balanced by λ, so its balance is hyperparameter-dependent, whereas EXCISE's retain safety holds by construction (Theorem 2); and SCRUB ascends the forget loss, which is unstable in either direction, whereas `kl_retain` converges to a specific target distribution.

Continual learning connection, and the closest prior work. A-GEM (Chaudhry et al., 2019) projects task gradients to avoid catastrophic forgetting. The CL–MU duality has been noted conceptually (Nguyen et al., 2020; Kurmanji et al., 2023). Closest to EXCISE, recent work (Patel & Qiu, 2025) also targets the forget–retain gradient conflict, but through an *implicit, soft* regulariser encouraging a positive inner product—with no per-step constraint and no formal guarantee. More broadly, gradient projection and conflict resolution are now actively explored for unlearning. Closest in mechanism is Projected-Gradient Unlearning (Hoang et al., 2024), which takes unlearning steps orthogonal to a gradient subspace estimated for the retained data. EXCISE differs in the constraint and in what it binds: a half-space against the current retain gradient—the minimum correction that excludes retain-harming steps—applied to the post-momentum update the optimiser actually takes. EXCISE enforces $\langle u_t, g_\mathrm{r} \rangle \geq 0$ explicitly at every step, on the post-momentum update, which is the difference between *softly discouraging* conflict and *provably eliminating* it—and, relative to guarantees stated for momentum-free surrogates, the difference between a bound that describes the deployed optimiser and one that does not. §F.9 tests the mechanism this distinction rests on by varying our own projection between a soft penalty and the hard constraint; a like-for-like run of that method on our stack remains future work.

B Design Details

B.1 From the Optimisation Problem to the Algorithm

This framing makes three things explicit that weighted multi-objective approaches conflate. First, retain safety is a *hard constraint*, not a soft penalty. Second, the forget objective sets the direction of the search and the forget-accuracy target its end point; only the second is a constraint. Third, the two tolerances (α, τ_F) are quantities a practitioner sets, not epochs to be tuned.

Why this needs a new algorithm. Writing down Eq. 2 is not by itself progress: one could hand it to a generic constrained solver, or relax it into the weighted objective that existing methods already optimise. Both routes lose the property we are after. A Lagrangian relaxation replaces the retain constraint with a penalty $\lambda \mathcal{L}_\mathrm{r}$, which is precisely the soft treatment whose feasible set still contains retain-harming steps (Theorem 2(iv)); and a projected-gradient solver applied naively would enforce feasibility on the gradient while the optimiser applies something else (Proposition 1). What the problem *does* buy is a specification: it says exactly which quantity each mechanism must control. EXCISE realises each condition with the cheapest mechanism we know that enforces it, and enforces retain safety at every step on the vector actually applied. Table 9 states that correspondence, and §4 derives each row.

B.2 What Is Taken from A-GEM, and What Is Not

The operator in Eq. 3 is A-GEM's, and we claim no novelty for it: the correction $v \mapsto v - \frac{\langle v, g \rangle}{\|g\|^2} g$ is the standard projection onto a half-space, and Chaudhry et al. (2019) introduced its use in continual learning with g the gradient on an episodic memory of past tasks. We also inherit its two attractive properties: it is the *minimum-norm* correction restoring feasibility, so it is the least destructive repair of a conflicting step, and it costs one extra backward pass and one inner product per step.

Table 9: **From the problem to the algorithm.** Each condition of Eq. 2, and the property of the search path, with the mechanism that enforces it. Two components serve no condition directly: the distillation anchor, which is part of the retain objective the projection protects, and the handling of BatchNorm statistics (§4.3).

Condition	**Mechanism**	**Enforced**
Retain objective does not increase along the path	Projection of the post-momentum update onto $\{\langle u, g_r\rangle \geq 0\}$ (§4.1–4.2)	Every step, to first order on the sampled batch (Thm. 1)
$\mathrm{CE}(\theta; \mathcal{D}_r) \leq \alpha\, \mathrm{CE}(\theta_0; \mathcal{D}_r)$	Retain-loss stopping rule (§4.3)	After every epoch, on the full retain set
$\mathrm{FA}(\theta; \mathcal{D}_f) \leq \tau_F$	Forget-accuracy stopping rule (§4.3)	Every m steps
Direction of the search	`kl_retain`: descend $\mathrm{KL}(p_\theta(x_f)\|p_r)$ (§4.3)	Every step
$\|\theta - \theta_0\| \leq R$	Clipping before accumulation, and the step budget	$\|\theta_N - \theta_0\| \leq N\eta c/(1-\mu)$

What is new is what the operator is asked to do. In A-GEM the projection is a safeguard on a process whose objective already points the right way—the new task is being learned, and the memory gradient only occasionally interferes; in our runs the conflict is not occasional but universal, firing at 100% of steps (§F.4), because erasing a class and preserving the rest are directly opposed rather than incidentally so. The projection is therefore not a correction applied to an optimiser but the optimiser's defining step. That change of role has three consequences, and they are what §4.2 is about:

1. *It must bind the applied vector.* A-GEM projects a gradient; with momentum the applied vector is not the gradient, and projecting the gradient certifies nothing (Proposition 1).

2. *Its magnitude matters.* A-GEM tolerates $\|\Pi_{g_r}(v)\| \leq \|v\|$ because progress on the new task comes mostly from unconflicted steps. When every step conflicts, that contraction compounds and forgetting stalls, so we restore the norm after projecting.

3. *It bounds nothing on the forget side.* The projection guarantees retain safety and only that; on its own it does not unlearn. Our projection-only ablation reaches forget accuracy 18.66% against a 10% chance level (Table 4), which is why Excise pairs it with a forget objective rather than presenting the projection as a method.

B.3 The Three Ordering Choices

Excise uses SGD with momentum μ, weight decay λ_{wd}, and gradient clipping c. Three ordering choices determine whether the guarantee is real, and all three matter empirically.

(i) Project the update, not the gradient. The vector applied to the weights is u_t, not g_f. We therefore momentum-accumulate first and project afterwards (Algorithm 1, lines 10–15), so that $\langle u_t, g_\mathrm{r}\rangle \geq 0$ holds for the update that is actually applied. Projecting g_f instead leaves $\langle u_t, g_\mathrm{r}\rangle$ unconstrained.

(ii) Clip before accumulating. Clipping is applied to the per-step ingredient d_t *before* it enters the momentum buffer. This preserves the standard SGD semantics in which momentum accumulates clipped gradients, and yields the bound $\|v_t\| \leq c/(1-\mu)$ used in Theorem 1. Clipping the final update instead would cap $\|u_t\| \leq c$, destroying the $1/(1-\mu)$ amplification that momentum provides; since raw forget gradients are $\sim$100$\times$ the clip threshold in our runs, clipping is always active, and this ordering is the difference between forgetting and not forgetting.

(iii) Preserve magnitude under projection. Projection is norm-non-increasing: $\|\Pi_{g_r}(v)\| = \|v\| \sin\vartheta$ where ϑ is the angle between v and g_r. When forget and retain gradients are nearly antiparallel, $\sin\vartheta \approx 0$ and the applied step collapses, stalling forgetting for reasons unrelated to retain safety. We therefore rescale the projected update to the pre-projection norm, $u_t = \Pi_{g_r}(v_t)\,\|v_t\|/\|\Pi_{g_r}(v_t)\|$. Because $\langle u, g_r\rangle = 0$ is invariant to positive rescaling, this leaves the guarantee untouched while decoupling forgetting speed from conflict severity. (If $\Pi_{g_r}(v_t) = 0$, i.e. v_t is exactly antiparallel to g_r, we set $u_t = 0$; the guarantee holds trivially.)

B.4 The Forget Objective

The `kl_retain` objective of Eq. 4 targets p_r, where p_r (Eq. 1) is the model's natural confusion pattern. The motivation is that no trained model produces uniform outputs, so a model driven toward $\mathcal{U}(K)$ remains separable from a retrained one even at FA = 0%; a forget target drawn from the model's own behaviour on retained data does not have that artefact. Under the previous implementation this was supported empirically, with the uniform target giving MIA AUROC = 0.469 against 0.496 for `kl_retain`. **Re-measured under the projected-momentum optimiser, it is not.** The three forget objectives give, on CIFAR-10 class 0: gradient ascent TA/FA/MIA = 86.4/8.2/0.559, KL-uniform 86.4/3.9/0.526, and `kl_retain` 86.1/2.1/0.528. Both KL variants clearly beat gradient ascent, which neither forgets as far nor stays as close to the ideal MIA. Between the two, however, the difference is within noise and if anything favours uniform ($|\text{MIA} - 0.5| = 0.026$ against 0.028).

We therefore keep `kl_retain` for its lower forget accuracy at equal test accuracy, and retract the claim that it is distinguishable from the uniform target on MIA grounds. This is consistent with §F.13: p_r is not what a retrained model produces on forget inputs, so an argument resting on p_r being the "natural" target was never on firm ground. What survives is narrower—p_r is a better forget *direction* than uniform, and no more. It is not a claim that p_r is what a retrained model outputs on forget inputs: §F.13 and Appendix J show it is not, and that minimising the divergence to it is harmful.

B.5 Supporting Components

KD-anchored stability. A frozen copy of θ_0 serves as teacher, $\mathcal{L}_{\text{KD}} = T^2\text{KL}(\sigma(f_\theta(x_r)/T)\|\sigma(f_{\theta_0}(x_r)/T))$, anchoring behaviour on $\mathcal{D}_r$ and complementing the projection.

C Notation, Assumptions, and the Analysed Update

We restate the update exactly as implemented, since the entire point of Theorem 1 is that the analysed object and the executed object coincide.

Notation. $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\text{r}}(\theta)$ is the retain objective $\mathcal{L}_{\text{r}}$ of §3—cross-entropy plus $\beta\mathcal{L}_{\text{KD}}(\theta, \theta_0; \mathcal{D}_r)$—evaluated on the sampled retain mini-batch at step t, and $g_{\text{r}} := \nabla_\theta \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\text{r}}(\theta_t)$ its gradient. Note β does not appear separately in the bounds because g_{r} is already the composite gradient. $g_{\text{f}} := \nabla_\theta \mathcal{L}_{\text{f}}(\theta_t; x_f)$ is the forget gradient on the forget mini-batch. $\lambda_{\text{wd}} \geq 0$ is weight decay, $c > 0$ the clipping threshold, $\eta > 0$ the learning rate, and $\mu \in [0, 1)$ the momentum coefficient. $\|\cdot\|$ is the Euclidean norm on the concatenation of all trainable parameters.

The projection operator. For $g \neq 0$ define

$$\Pi_g(v) \;=\; \begin{cases} v, & \langle v, g\rangle \geq 0, \\ v - \dfrac{\langle v, g\rangle}{\|g\|^2}\, g, & \langle v, g\rangle < 0, \end{cases} \qquad \widehat{\Pi}_g(v) \;=\; \begin{cases} \Pi_g(v)\,\dfrac{\|v\|}{\|\Pi_g(v)\|}, & \Pi_g(v) \neq 0, \\ 0, & \Pi_g(v) = 0, \end{cases} \tag{6}$$

where $\widehat{\Pi}$ is the *magnitude-preserving* variant used by Excise (§4.2). In the implementation the case $\Pi_g(v) = 0$ is detected by the guard $\|\Pi_g(v)\| \leq \epsilon\|v\|$ with $\epsilon = 10^{-8}$.

The analysed (and executed) update. With $v_{-1} = 0$, for $t = 0, 1, 2, \ldots$

$$d_t = \mathrm{clip}_c\big(g_{\mathrm{f}}^{(t)} + \lambda_{\mathrm{wd}}\theta_t\big), \qquad \text{where } \mathrm{clip}_c(x) = x \cdot \min\big(1, c/\|x\|\big), \tag{7}$$

$$v_t = \mu\, v_{t-1} + d_t, \tag{8}$$

$$u_t = \widehat{\Pi}_{g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)}}(v_t), \tag{9}$$

$$\theta_{t+1} = \theta_t - \eta\, u_t. \tag{10}$$

Three orderings are load-bearing and are stated here so they cannot be lost in implementation: clipping acts on d_t *before* the momentum accumulation (7)–(8); the projection acts on the accumulated v_t, i.e. on the update rather than on the gradient (9); and no clipping is applied after (9).

Assumptions.

(A1) $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}$ is L-smooth: $\|\nabla\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(x) - \nabla\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(y)\| \le L\|x - y\|$ for all x, y.

(A2) Clipping is applied as in (7), so $\|d_t\| \le c$ for all t.

(A3) $\mu \in [0, 1)$.

(A1) is the standard smoothness assumption of first-order analysis; for ReLU networks it holds piecewise, and we treat it as an idealisation, as is conventional. (A2) and (A3) are properties of the implementation, not assumptions about the data.

D Proof of Theorem 1

We prove three lemmas and then assemble the theorem.

Lemma 1 (Projection properties)**.** *Let $g \neq 0$ and v be arbitrary. Then*

(i) $\langle \Pi_g(v), g\rangle \ge 0$*, with equality whenever* $\langle v, g\rangle < 0$*;*

(ii) $\|\Pi_g(v)\| \le \|v\|$*;*

(iii) $\langle \widehat{\Pi}_g(v), g\rangle \ge 0$ *and* $\|\widehat{\Pi}_g(v)\| \le \|v\|$*, with* $\|\widehat{\Pi}_g(v)\| = \|v\|$ *whenever* $\Pi_g(v) \neq 0$*.*

Proof. (i) If $\langle v, g\rangle \ge 0$ then $\Pi_g(v) = v$ and the claim is immediate. If $\langle v, g\rangle < 0$ then

$$\langle \Pi_g(v), g\rangle = \Big\langle v - \tfrac{\langle v,g\rangle}{\|g\|^2} g,\ g \Big\rangle = \langle v, g\rangle - \tfrac{\langle v,g\rangle}{\|g\|^2}\|g\|^2 = 0.$$

(ii) In the first branch this is an equality. In the second branch, Π_g is the orthogonal projection onto the hyperplane $\{u : \langle u, g\rangle = 0\}$; writing $v = \Pi_g(v) + \frac{\langle v,g\rangle}{\|g\|^2} g$ as a sum of two orthogonal vectors, Pythagoras gives

$$\|v\|^2 = \|\Pi_g(v)\|^2 + \frac{\langle v, g\rangle^2}{\|g\|^2} \ \ge\ \|\Pi_g(v)\|^2. \tag{11}$$

(iii) If $\Pi_g(v) = 0$ then $\widehat{\Pi}_g(v) = 0$ and both claims are trivial. Otherwise $\widehat{\Pi}_g(v) = s\,\Pi_g(v)$ with $s = \|v\|/\|\Pi_g(v)\| > 0$, so $\langle \widehat{\Pi}_g(v), g\rangle = s\langle \Pi_g(v), g\rangle \ge 0$ by (i), and $\|\widehat{\Pi}_g(v)\| = s\|\Pi_g(v)\| = \|v\|$. □

Part (iii) is the formal content of the design choice in §4.2(iii): rescaling restores the magnitude that (11) removes, and because $s > 0$ it cannot flip the sign of the inner product. The guarantee is therefore invariant to the rescaling, while the step magnitude is not.

Lemma 2 (Velocity norm bound)**.** *Under (A2) and (A3), for every $t \ge 0$,*

$$\|v_t\| \ \le\ c\,\frac{1 - \mu^{\,t+1}}{1 - \mu} \ <\ \frac{c}{1 - \mu}. \tag{12}$$

Proof. Unrolling (8) from $v_{-1} = 0$ gives $v_t = \sum_{k=0}^{t} \mu^{t-k} d_k$. By the triangle inequality and (A2),

$$\|v_t\| \;\le\; \sum_{k=0}^{t} \mu^{t-k} \|d_k\| \;\le\; c \sum_{j=0}^{t} \mu^{j} \;=\; c\,\frac{1-\mu^{t+1}}{1-\mu} \;<\; \frac{c}{1-\mu},$$

the last step using $\mu \in [0, 1)$ so that $\mu^{t+1} > 0$ and the geometric series converges. □

Lemma 2 is where the clip-before-momentum ordering is used: it requires $\|d_k\| \le c$ for the *ingredients* of the sum. Note also that the bound is attained only in the limit of perfectly aligned successive steps; we observe $\max_t \|u_t\| = 9.16$ against $c/(1-\mu) = 10$ in §F.4, so it is tight in practice.

Lemma 3 (Descent step)**.** *Under (A1), for any vector u and $\theta_+ = \theta_t - \eta u$,*

$$\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_+) \;\le\; \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_t) - \eta \langle u, g_{\mathrm{r}} \rangle + \tfrac{1}{2} L \eta^2 \|u\|^2. \tag{13}$$

Proof. Standard consequence of L-smoothness (the descent lemma): (A1) implies $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(y) \le \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(x) + \langle \nabla \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(x), y - x \rangle + \frac{L}{2}\|y - x\|^2$ for all x, y. Substituting $x = \theta_t$, $y = \theta_+$, so that $y - x = -\eta u$ and $\nabla \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(x) = g_{\mathrm{r}}$, gives (13). □

Theorem 3 (Theorem 1, restated)**.** *Under (A1)–(A3), the update (7)–(10) satisfies, at every step t and unconditionally,*

$$\textit{(a)} \quad \langle u_t, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)} \rangle \;\ge\; 0, \tag{14}$$

$$\textit{(b)} \quad \|u_t\| \;\le\; \|v_t\| \;<\; \frac{c}{1-\mu}, \quad \textit{with } \|u_t\| = \|v_t\| \textit{ unless } \Pi_{g_{\mathrm{r}}}(v_t) = 0, \tag{15}$$

$$\textit{(c)} \quad \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_{t+1}) \;\le\; \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_t) + \tfrac{1}{2} L \eta^2 \Big(\frac{c}{1-\mu} \Big)^2. \tag{16}$$

Proof. (a) Immediate from Lemma 1(iii) applied to v_t with $g = g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)}$, using (9). If $g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)} = 0$ the projection is undefined and is skipped; then $\langle u_t, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)} \rangle = 0$ and (a) holds trivially (see Remark 2).

(b) Combine Lemma 1(iii) with Lemma 2.

(c) By Lemma 3 with $u = u_t$,

$$\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_{t+1}) \le \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_t) - \eta \underbrace{\langle u_t, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)} \rangle}_{\ge 0 \text{ by (a)}} + \tfrac{1}{2} L \eta^2 \underbrace{\|u_t\|^2}_{< (c/(1-\mu))^2 \text{ by (b)}} \;\le\; \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_t) + \tfrac{1}{2} L \eta^2 \Big(\frac{c}{1-\mu} \Big)^2.$$ □

The first-order change in the sampled retain objective is thus non-positive at every step; the only admissible increase is the $O(\eta^2)$ curvature term. The guarantee is *unconditional* in the sense that it requires no assumption on g_{f}, on the alignment between forget and retain gradients, or on the data.

Corollary 1 (Momentum-free reduction)**.** *Setting $\mu = 0$ gives $v_t = d_t$, $\|u_t\| \le c$, and $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_{t+1}) \le \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_t) + \frac{1}{2} L \eta^2 c^2$, recovering the momentum-free per-step bound.*

Corollary 2 (A-GEM reduction)**.** *Setting $\mu = 0$, $c = \infty$ and letting $\eta \to 0$ recovers the first-order A-GEM guarantee $\langle u_t, g_{\mathrm{r}} \rangle \ge 0$ (Chaudhry et al., 2019).*

Corollary 1 is worth reading alongside Table 5: the $\mu = 0$ bound is *formally tighter* (by a factor $(1-\mu)^{-2} = 100$ at $\mu = 0.9$), yet the configuration it describes fails to unlearn on five of six datasets. A tighter bound on a method that does not forget is not the better result—which is precisely why we analyse the update that is actually run.

D.1 Why the Projection Must Be Applied to the Update

The following proposition shows that the design choice of §4.2(i) is not a matter of convenience: projecting the *gradient* provides no per-step guarantee once $\mu > 0$, however carefully each individual gradient is projected.

Proposition 1 (Gradient-projection is insufficient under momentum)**.** *Consider the variant that projects the gradient and then accumulates momentum:*

$$\tilde{d}_t = \mathrm{clip}_c\big(\Pi_{g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)}}(g_{\mathrm{f}}^{(t)})\big), \qquad v_t = \mu v_{t-1} + \tilde{d}_t, \qquad \theta_{t+1} = \theta_t - \eta v_t,$$

so that every accumulated ingredient satisfies $\langle \tilde{d}_t, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)} \rangle \geq 0$. Then for every $\mu \in (0,1)$ there exist retain and forget gradients for which the applied update v_t satisfies $\langle v_t, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)} \rangle < 0$, i.e. the step strictly increases the sampled retain loss to first order.

Proof. Work in $\mathbb{R}^2$ with $\lambda_{\mathrm{wd}} = 0$, $c = \infty$ (clipping inactive), and $v_{-1} = 0$.

Step 0. Let $g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(0)} = (1,0)$ and $g_{\mathrm{f}}^{(0)} = (-1,1)$. Then $\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}^{(0)}, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(0)} \rangle = -1 < 0$, so the projection fires:

$$\tilde{d}_0 = \Pi_{g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(0)}}(g_{\mathrm{f}}^{(0)}) = (-1,1) - \frac{-1}{1}(1,0) = (0,1),$$

which is retain-safe, $\langle \tilde{d}_0, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(0)} \rangle = 0$. Hence $v_0 = (0,1)$.

Step 1. Let the retain mini-batch change so that $g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(1)} = (0,-1)$, and let $g_{\mathrm{f}}^{(1)} = (1,0)$. Then $\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}^{(1)}, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(1)} \rangle = 0 \geq 0$, so no projection is needed and $\tilde{d}_1 = (1,0)$, again retain-safe: $\langle \tilde{d}_1, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(1)} \rangle = 0$. The applied update is

$$v_1 = \mu v_0 + \tilde{d}_1 = \mu(0,1) + (1,0) = (1,\mu), \qquad \langle v_1, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(1)} \rangle = \langle (1,\mu), (0,-1) \rangle = -\mu \ < \ 0$$

for every $\mu > 0$. By Lemma 3 the first-order change in $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}$ is $-\eta \langle v_1, g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(1)} \rangle = +\eta\mu > 0$: the retain loss strictly increases to first order, even though *every* projected gradient entering the buffer was individually retain-safe. □

The mechanism is transparent: the momentum buffer carries a direction that was certified against $g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(0)}$ into a step whose constraint is $g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(1)}$, and the projection at step 1 never inspects the carried term. Projecting v_t itself (9) removes exactly this failure, because the certificate is issued against the constraint in force at the step where the update is applied. Note also that μ appears linearly in the violation, so the defect grows with the momentum coefficient rather than vanishing.

D.2 Why Clipping Must Precede Accumulation

Proposition 2 (Clipping the update destroys momentum amplification)**.** *Consider the variant that clips the final update, $u_t = \mathrm{clip}_c(\widehat{\Pi}_{g_{\mathrm{r}}}(\mu v_{t-1} + \tilde{g}_t))$ with $\tilde{g}_t$ unclipped. Then $\|u_t\| \leq c$ for all t, identical to the bound obtained at $\mu = 0$ (Corollary 1), irrespective of μ.*

Proof. Immediate from the definition of clip_c. □

Proposition 2 is trivial as mathematics but decisive in practice. In our runs the raw forget-gradient norm is $\sim$100$\times$ the clipping threshold ($\|g_{\mathrm{f}}\| \in [102, 149]$ with $c = 1$ on CIFAR-10), so clipping is active at every step and the cap is always attained. Clipping after accumulation therefore yields an applied step of magnitude exactly ηc — the same magnitude as the momentum-free configuration, and hence the same failure to forget documented in Table 5. The ordering in (7)–(8) instead admits $\|v_t\| \to c/(1-\mu)$, a 10$\times$ larger step at $\mu = 0.9$, while Lemma 2 keeps it bounded. The bound in (16) is looser by $(1-\mu)^{-2}$ as a result; this is the price of a guarantee that describes an optimiser that unlearns.

D.3 Remarks on Scope and Exactness

Remark 1 (Mini-batch scope). $g_{\mathrm{r}}^{(t)}$ is the gradient of the retain objective on the *sampled* retain mini-batch, so (16) is exact for that mini-batch's objective—which is the quantity EXCISE projects against, and therefore the quantity about which a per-step statement can be made. Because mini-batch gradients are unbiased estimates of the population gradient, the first-order term is non-positive in expectation up to the standard SGD gradient-variance term; a population-exact per-step guarantee would require the full retain gradient at every step, at $O(|\mathcal{D}_r|)$ cost per update. We regard this as the principal formal limitation (§7).

Remark 2 (Degenerate retain gradient). The implementation skips the projection when $\|g_{\mathrm{r}}\|^2 < 10^{-12}$, since (6) is then numerically ill-posed. In that regime the violation of (14) is bounded by Cauchy–Schwarz: $|\langle u_t, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle| \le \|u_t\|\|g_{\mathrm{r}}\| \le 10^{-6}c/(1-\mu)$, giving a first-order retain increase of at most $10^{-5}\eta$. Moreover such a g_{r} means the retain mini-batch is already at a stationary point. The exception is therefore quantitatively negligible, but we state it rather than suppress it.

Remark 3 (Floating-point exactness). In exact arithmetic $\langle \Pi_g(v), g\rangle = 0$ identically. In float32, the inner products are sums over 1.12×10^7 parameters, with accumulation error of order $\sqrt{n}\,\varepsilon_{32} \approx 4 \times 10^{-4}$ relative. The measured worst-case relative violation is -7.4×10^{-7} (§F.4), three orders of magnitude *below* that scale and with positive mean, consistent with rounding rather than a systematic defect. We therefore state Theorem 3 as holding to float32 precision, and recommend float64 accumulation for the inner products in (6) in reference implementations.

E Proof of Theorem 2

Theorem 4 (Theorem 2, restated)**.** *Fix θ_0 with retain gradient $g_{\mathrm{r}} := \nabla\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_0) \neq 0$ and forget gradient g_{f}. Consider one-step update operators. Then:*

(i) ***GA.*** *The update $\theta_0 + \eta g_{\mathrm{f}}$ strictly increases $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}$ to first order whenever $\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle > 0$.*

(ii) ***SCRUB.*** *For any fixed $\lambda > 0$ there exist $g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}$ with $\langle -g_{\mathrm{f}} + \lambda g_{\mathrm{r}},\ g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle < 0$.*

(iii) ***SalUn.*** *The masked random-label update $-M \odot \nabla \mathrm{CE}_{\mathrm{RL}}$ has unconstrained sign with respect to g_{r}.*

(iv) ***Soft conflict regularisers.*** *Penalising negative alignment does not preclude it.*

(v) **Excise.** *$\langle u_t, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle \ge 0$ unconditionally.*

Proof. (i) A first-order expansion gives $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_0 + \eta g_{\mathrm{f}}) = \widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_0) + \eta\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle + O(\eta^2)$, which exceeds $\widetilde{\mathcal{L}}_{\mathrm{r}}(\theta_0)$ for small $\eta > 0$ when $\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle > 0$. Since GA constrains neither the sign nor the magnitude of $\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle$, no configuration-independent per-step guarantee is available.

(ii) Compute $\langle -g_{\mathrm{f}} + \lambda g_{\mathrm{r}},\ g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle = -\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle + \lambda\|g_{\mathrm{r}}\|^2$. This is negative precisely when $\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle > \lambda\|g_{\mathrm{r}}\|^2$. Such a pair exists for any fixed λ: e.g. in $\mathbb{R}^2$ take $g_{\mathrm{r}} = (1, 0)$ and $g_{\mathrm{f}} = (\lambda + 1)\,(1, 0)$, giving $\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle = \lambda + 1 > \lambda = \lambda\|g_{\mathrm{r}}\|^2$. Because λ is a fixed hyperparameter while $\langle g_{\mathrm{f}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle/\|g_{\mathrm{r}}\|^2$ varies along the trajectory, no fixed λ certifies every step.

(iii) With random labels the masked gradient direction is uncorrelated with g_{r} in expectation; individual draws therefore realise either sign of $\langle g_{\mathrm{SalUn}}, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle$, and the mask M (selected by gradient magnitude, not by retain alignment) imposes no constraint on it.

(iv) A regulariser adding $\rho\,\phi(\langle g, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle)$ to the objective with ϕ decreasing shifts the optimum toward positive alignment but leaves the feasible set unrestricted: for any finite penalty weight ρ, a sufficiently large forget-loss reduction makes a step with $\langle g, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle < 0$ preferable. Only a hard constraint—i.e. a projection onto $\{u : \langle u, g_{\mathrm{r}}\rangle \ge 0\}$—renders such steps unreachable.

(v) Theorem 3(a). □

Remark 4. Theorem 4 is a *worst-case* separation: it exhibits configurations in which the baselines strictly degrade the retain objective in a single step, not a claim that they typically do. In practice all these methods

often produce small retain-loss changes. The distinction the theorem draws is between behaviour that is empirically usual and behaviour that is guaranteed by construction; only the latter is checkable without running the method.

F Extended Experimental Results

F.1 Datasets, Baselines and Metrics

We also fix the four quantities used to evaluate unlearning throughout, so that they are available before the algorithm is stated. *Test accuracy* (TA) is measured on the held-out test set and reports how much of the model's general utility survives. *Forget accuracy* (FA) is measured on $\mathcal{D}_f$; because a retrained model has never seen those samples, a fully unlearned model should drive FA down to at most the chance level $100/K\%$. *Retain accuracy* (RA) is measured on $\mathcal{D}_r$ and should not move. Finally, a *membership-inference attack* (MIA) tries to distinguish forget-set training samples from forget-set test samples, and we score it by the area under its receiver-operating-characteristic curve (AUROC); this is conventionally read against an ideal of 0.5, a convention §F.12 shows to be the wrong reference point.

Datasets. We evaluate on six image-classification benchmarks chosen to vary the three factors that plausibly govern how hard class-level unlearning is: the number of classes, the number of examples per class, and the semantic distance between the forgotten class and the retained ones.

CIFAR-10 (Krizhevsky, 2009) is the standard unlearning benchmark and serves as our reference setting. MNIST (LeCun et al., 1998) and SVHN (Netzer et al., 2011) share its ten-class structure but differ in difficulty and in how strongly classes overlap, which lets us separate the method's behaviour from the particular geometry of CIFAR-10. CIFAR-100 (Krizhevsky, 2009) raises the class count tenfold, lowering the chance level to 1% and shrinking each forget set to 500 images—a regime where "forgotten" is a far stricter requirement. STL-10 (Coates et al., 2011) isolates data scarcity in the other direction: at 96×96 resolution with only 500 training images per class, the forget set yields roughly 60 optimiser steps, which stresses any method that must make progress under a per-step constraint. PathMNIST (Yang et al., 2023) moves off natural images entirely to histopathology tissue types, where class boundaries are less separable and where deletion requests are a realistic rather than hypothetical requirement.

Forgetting a single class can be unrepresentative—classes differ substantially in difficulty—so wherever cost permits we forget *every* class in turn: all ten for MNIST and all nine for PathMNIST, with per-class results reported in Appendix H rather than only in aggregate. For CIFAR-100 we sample one class per tens group (classes 10–90) to cover the label space at tractable cost, and for CIFAR-10, SVHN, and STL-10 we forget class 0 across three seeds to quantify run-to-run variance. This gives 31 forgetting tasks and 75 unlearning runs in total.

Model, baselines, metrics. All experiments use ResNet-18 (He et al., 2016) (11.7M parameters). We compare against a model retrained without the forget class, SalUn (Fan et al., 2024), SCRUB (Kurmanji et al., 2023), Bad Teacher (Chundawat et al., 2023), and NegGrad+ (Thudi et al., 2022), all re-run on our stack; every MIA number except SalUn's in Table 4 comes from one attack implementation, the mean AUROC of a loss and a confidence attack, rather than being quoted from each method's own paper. We report the four metrics defined in §3: TA, FA, RA, and MIA AUROC. Two reminders about FA are worth repeating here: the target is the chance level $100/K\%$ rather than zero, and a retrained reference in fact reaches ≈0% because it routes forget-class inputs to surviving classes.

Hyperparameters. CIFAR-10: $\eta = 5{\times}10^{-4}$, $\mu = 0.9$, $\beta = 2.0$, $c = 1.0$, $\alpha = 5.0$, $T_{\mathrm{KD}} = 4.0$. Other datasets use $\eta = 2{\times}10^{-4}$, $\beta \in [3, 5]$. All configs are released as YAML.

F.2 Cross-Dataset Results in Detail

Table 3 reports the main results. At each dataset's epoch cap Excise drives FA to or below the chance level on four of six datasets and holds RA $\geq$ 97.2% everywhere except CIFAR-100 (92.2%); at the extended

budget it reaches chance on all six. The mean over seeds is below chance for every MNIST and PathMNIST class. The two shortfalls in the upper block—STL-10 and CIFAR-100—are budget-limited rather than method-limited, and §F.2 separates the two explanations.

The per-dataset mean MIA AUROC stays within 0.035 of 0.5 on all six datasets. We report that because it is the conventional summary, but §F.12 shows 0.5 is not the right reference point for this protocol—and that no fixed reference point is—so it should not be read as evidence of successful unlearning on its own.

The MIA figure above is a per-dataset *mean*, and on PathMNIST that mean conceals a defect: two individual classes sit at 0.298 and 0.388, well *below* 0.5 rather than above it (Appendix H). We report this rather than let the aggregate absorb it, and we return to it in §F.13.

The two shortfalls are budget-limited, not method-limited. Table 3 sets an epoch cap per dataset (12–20 epochs), which penalises datasets with few images per class, since the binding resource is update steps rather than examples. STL-10 supplies only 4 forget mini-batches per epoch, so its 15-epoch cap buys ∼60 steps against ∼600 for CIFAR-10 at the same cap. Raising STL-10 to 60 epochs, with a per-step check and a 1% forget target, takes forget accuracy from 75.67% to **1.73**% over the same three seeds (1.0–2.8%), at RA = 98.87% and MIA = 0.488; a single 60-epoch run with the default 10% target stops at 9.20% after 30 epochs, so reaching chance does not depend on the tighter target. Test accuracy moves from 92.84% to 85.15%, which is not collateral damage but the arithmetic of having actually forgotten: TA is measured over all K classes, so removing one of ten costs a tenth of it, and $85.15 = 94.61 \times \frac{9}{10}$ leaves the retained classes at 94.61%. The same operation on CIFAR-10 gives $86.13 = 95.70 \times \frac{9}{10}$, so under the longer budget STL-10 behaves like the datasets that already worked rather than like a failure case.

CIFAR-100 responds likewise, and more informatively. Re-running all nine tens-group classes at 60 epochs takes the mean from 4.07% to $\mathbf{1.27 \pm 0.39}$% against a 1% chance level—so the chance level now lies within one standard deviation—while the spread across classes collapses from ±5.51 to ±0.39. The earlier variance was therefore not an intrinsic property of the 100-class setting but a symptom of some classes being halted before convergence: the outlier that failed to converge within 20 epochs (FA 17.8%) reaches 2.0% given 60. Retain accuracy costs 0.87pp for this (92.19 → 91.32).

Both re-runs use the same seeds and classes as the upper-block rows, with a per-step check, so we report them as a second block of Table 3 rather than substituting them into the first. The distinction is worth preserving: at the configured caps the method reaches chance on four of six datasets, and at a budget scaled to the data it reaches chance on all six. Which is the honest headline depends on whether a practitioner will spend three to four times the compute on small or many-class datasets, so we report both and label them.

The projection alone does not unlearn. The *projection-only* row is the direct projected-gradient baseline: A-GEM projection applied to plain gradient ascent, with the KD anchor and the retain-confusion target removed. It preserves the retain set almost perfectly (RA = 99.90%), which is what the guarantee promises and all that it promises—but it stops at FA = 18.66%, above the 10% chance level, and halts on the retain-loss budget rather than on the forget target. Read together with the equal-compute ablation (Table 14), where *removing* the projection costs 47.4pp of retain accuracy, this delineates the division of labour precisely: the projection supplies retain safety and nothing else, while the `kl_retain` objective is what actually drives forget accuracy to chance. Neither component is sufficient alone, which is the substantive content of the ablation.

CIFAR-100: scaling to 100 classes. Table 10 gives per-class results (base model TA = 78.5%, chance = 1%). EXCISE reduces FA from ∼99% to a mean of 4.07% (median 1.60%) while holding RA at 92.19%, with MIA averaging 0.500. Eight of nine classes reach FA ≤ 6.8%; class 60 is an outlier at 17.8% that does not converge within the 20-epoch budget, and it alone accounts for the gap between the mean and the median (excluding it, mean FA is 2.35%). Unlike the 10-class datasets, CIFAR-100 does not reach its 1% chance level, so we report it as a ∼95pp reduction rather than as forgetting to chance.

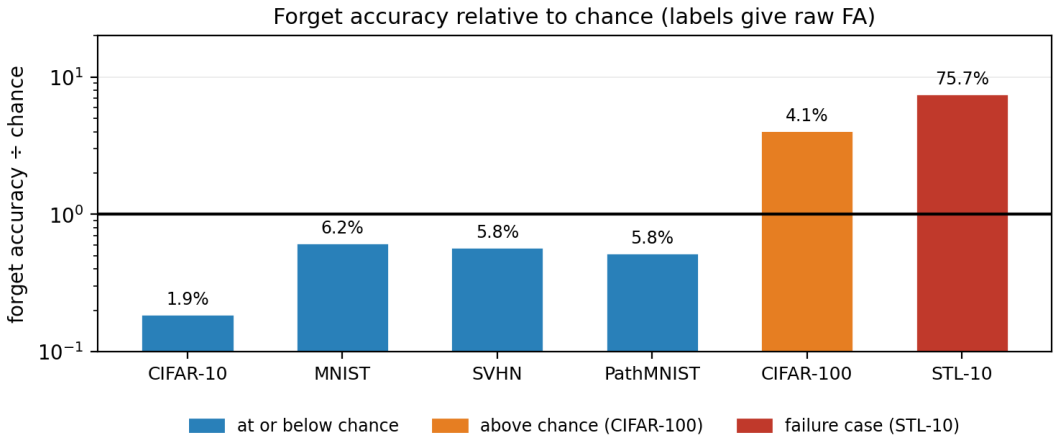


Figure 5: **Forget accuracy relative to the chance level.** Raw forget accuracy is not comparable across datasets: CIFAR-100's 4.1% is *above* its 1% chance level while MNIST's 6.2% is *below* its 10% one. Dividing by $100/K$ puts "at chance" at 1.0 everywhere. Four datasets sit below chance, CIFAR-100 above it despite a ∼95pp reduction, and STL-10 above it at its 15-epoch cap, though not at 60 epochs (§F.2).

Table 10: **CIFAR-100 class-level forgetting** (single seed per class, chance = 1%). *Class 60 does not converge within the 20-epoch budget.

Forget class	TA (%)	FA (%)↓	RA (%)	MIA
10	77.23	4.20	92.84	0.485
20	76.69	1.60	92.80	0.485
30	75.18	1.40	91.03	0.486
40	77.19	6.80	93.14	0.506
50	76.25	0.60	92.31	0.562
60*	76.76	17.80	92.86	0.445
70	75.38	1.60	90.89	0.482
80	74.95	1.00	91.51	0.553
90	75.87	1.60	92.32	0.498
Mean	**76.17**	**4.07**	**92.19**	**0.500**
Median	**76.25**	**1.60**	**92.31**	**0.486**

F.3 Momentum in Detail

The most direct route to an exact per-step guarantee is to remove momentum, so that the applied update *is* the projected gradient. Table 5 shows what that costs. With $\mu = 0$ and all else fixed, EXCISE fails to forget on five of six datasets: FA remains at 95.9% on MNIST, 99.7% on STL-10, 73.7% on CIFAR-100, and 61.9% on SVHN. Retain accuracy stays high throughout—but only because the model barely moves; high RA together with high FA is the signature of a method that preserves retained knowledge by declining to unlearn.

This is the empirical content of our central methodological claim. A per-step guarantee stated for the momentum-free update would be exact and implementation-matched, yet would describe a method that does not unlearn. Projecting the post-momentum update instead keeps the guarantee exact *and* recovers forgetting on every dataset where it is attainable.

Is the dependence ours, or the field's? A natural objection is that this ablation only tells us something about EXCISE. If every gradient-based unlearning rule collapses without momentum, the finding is about

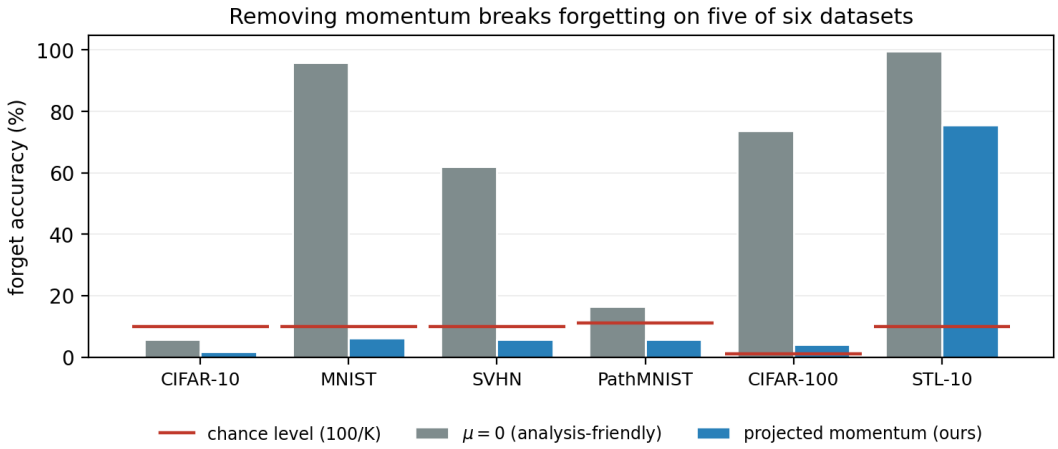


Figure 6: **Momentum is not incidental.** Forget accuracy with momentum removed ($\mu = 0$, grey) against the projected-momentum update (blue), with each dataset's chance level in red. The momentum-free configuration—the one for which an exact guarantee is easiest to state—fails to forget on five of six datasets. Retain accuracy stays high throughout (Table 5), because the model barely moves.

Table 11: **Where the momentum dependence comes from** (equal compute, 12 epochs on MNIST and 15 on SVHN, dual stopping disabled). Δ is the increase in forget accuracy when momentum is removed, so larger is more dependent. Grouping by forget objective separates the rows cleanly; grouping by whether the projection is used does not.

Update rule	Forget objective	Projection	MNIST Δ	SVHN Δ	mean
EXCISE	KL $\to p_r$	yes	+95.3	+62.4	**+78.8**
`kl_uniform`	KL $\to$ uniform	yes	+84.9	+56.3	**+70.6**
projection only	gradient ascent	yes	+16.5	+13.2	+14.8
gradient ascent	gradient ascent	no	+11.5	+12.5	+12.0

optimisers and not about our design; if only ours does, the hard constraint is fragile. We therefore repeated the ablation across four update rules on the two datasets where Table 5 shows the largest effect, at *equal compute* with stopping disabled so that the momentum change is not confounded with step count (Table 11).

Every rule degrades without momentum, including plain gradient ascent, which uses no projection at all—so the dependence is not an artefact of operating under a hard per-step constraint. But the rules do not degrade equally, and the grouping is informative. The two KL-based objectives lose 70–79pp of forget accuracy on average, the two gradient-ascent objectives 12–15pp: a factor of 5.6. Meanwhile the like-for-like comparison that isolates the projection—gradient ascent with it (+14.8) against gradient ascent without it (+12.0)—differs by only 2.8pp.

The momentum dependence therefore belongs to the *forget objective*, not to the projection. The reason is visible in the objective itself: $\mathrm{KL}(p_\theta(x_f)\|p_r)$ is bounded and its gradient vanishes as $p_\theta \to p_r$, so the per-step signal is small and the $1/(1-\mu) = 10\times$ amplification that momentum supplies (Lemma 2) is what makes progress possible at all. Gradient ascent maximises an unbounded loss and needs no such amplification, which is also why it damages the retained model.

This sharpens rather than weakens the section's claim. The point was never that momentum is uniquely important to EXCISE; it is that the guarantee must be stated for the update the optimiser applies, and any method whose objective requires momentum inherits that requirement. A momentum-free analysis is convenient for exactly the objectives that cannot afford to be momentum-free.

Table 12: **Excise with a GroupNorm backbone** (3-seed means). GroupNorm removes the BN-recalibration vulnerability structurally. *STL-10 is under-trained under both backbones.

Dataset	TA	FA↓	RA	MIA
CIFAR-10	84.16	3.44	99.23	0.478
MNIST	90.17	5.84	99.31	0.500
SVHN	87.99	3.46	95.49	0.581
STL-10*	83.92	97.60	92.95	0.552
PathMNIST	72.00	2.71	95.97	0.583

F.4 Auditing the Guarantee at Step Level

We log every gradient step of a CIFAR-10 class-0 run (120 steps) and check Theorem 1 directly rather than assuming it.

- **The constraint is active, not vacuous.** All 120/120 steps have $\langle v_t, g_r \rangle < 0$, so the projection fires at every step. Projection here is not an occasional correction: without it, every step would increase retain loss to first order.
- **The guarantee holds.** After projection, $\langle u_t, g_r \rangle \geq 0$ at every step to floating-point precision. The largest relative violation is $\langle u_t, g_r \rangle / (\|u_t\| \|g_r\|) = -7.4 \times 10^{-7}$, against a float32 accumulation scale of $\sim 4 \times 10^{-4}$ for sums over 11.2M parameters; the mean relative alignment is positive ($+2.2 \times 10^{-8}$). The implied worst-case first-order retain increase is 3.1×10^{-7}, three orders of magnitude below the observed per-step retain-loss fluctuation (1.8×10^{-4}). We therefore state the guarantee as holding to float32 precision, and recommend float64 accumulation for the inner products in reference implementations.
- **The norm bound is respected.** $\|u_t\|$ reaches a maximum of 9.16 against the theoretical bound $c/(1-\mu) = 10$, with mean 7.35—close to but never exceeding the bound, confirming both that the bound is tight and that momentum's amplification is being realised.
- **Retain loss is controlled.** The mean per-step change in mini-batch retain CE is -7.9×10^{-5} (i.e. decreasing), with a maximum single-step increase of $+1.05 \times 10^{-3}$, consistent with the $O(\eta^2)$ term of Eq. 5.

F.5 BatchNorm Recalibration in Detail

Table 12 reports Excise with a GroupNorm backbone across datasets. GroupNorm keeps forgetting intact on four of five datasets at a modest TA cost (e.g. CIFAR-10 84.16% vs 86.13%), while removing the BN-recalibration mechanism by construction, since there are no batch statistics to recalibrate. STL-10 is under-trained under GroupNorm as it is under BN, at its epoch cap (§F.2).

Table 6 reports the diagnostic itself. The operator is `torch.optim.swa_utils.update_bn` applied to the retain set: it resets every BatchNorm buffer, sets the momentum to `None` so that PyTorch accumulates a cumulative rather than exponential average, and runs forward passes with no backward pass and no weight update. The resulting statistics are therefore the exact retain-set statistics, independent of the pre-attack buffers and idempotent in the data. We verify after every run that all learnable parameters are bit-identical, so nothing but the buffers can have changed. Then $\Delta F = \text{post} - \text{pre}$ separates weight-level forgetting ($\Delta F \approx 0$) from forgetting mediated by batch statistics ($\Delta F \gg 0$). We also report a weaker variant—forward passes in `train` mode under the default exponential average, which is what an earlier version of this work used—and the two agree to within 1.2pp on every row, and to 0.02pp on the Excise row that carries the finding, so the choice of estimator is not what drives the result. All accuracies here are measured under deterministic (test-time) transforms; leaving training augmentation active perturbs individual rows by several points.

The vulnerability is ours, not the field's—in our reproductions. The baseline rows matter more than EXCISE's. Every one of them is unaffected by recalibration—the largest movement is SCRUB's −3.6pp, in the direction of *more* forgetting—and so is the base model, which is the control that matters: recalibrating a normally trained network changes nothing, because its statistics already agree with its weights. Only EXCISE carries a mismatch. $\Delta F = +98.4$pp means the attack does not merely degrade the unlearning but *undoes* it: forget accuracy returns to 99.7% and test accuracy to 92.9%—the values recalibration gives the base model itself (99.8% and 92.9%)—without a single weight being modified. On a BatchNorm backbone, what EXCISE produces is not an unlearned model but an unlearned model's statistics.

We qualify the first half of that heading deliberately. Concurrent work (Kalani et al., 2026) reports large recoveries for SalUn (+62.1pp) and Bad Teacher (+78.2pp) under their reference implementations, where we measure none. We ran the identical operator, so the disagreement is not in the attack but in how the unlearned checkpoints were produced. Our implementations end every epoch with a full pass over retained data in train mode, which recomputes the running statistics before the checkpoint is saved; Kalani et al. (2026) run Bad Teacher's BatchNorm in eval mode, and find that SalUn's recovery disappears once at least a quarter of each unlearning batch is retained data. Our claim is therefore that the vulnerability is EXCISE-specific *among the checkpoints we trained*, not that these baselines are immune in general.

We attribute it, tentatively, to the interaction between our own design choice and BatchNorm. EXCISE freezes the normalisation statistics during unlearning so that class-homogeneous forget batches cannot corrupt them; the weights therefore adapt against *fixed* statistics, and the resulting decision boundary is valid only for those statistics. Methods that let the statistics move during unlearning never build that dependence. Freezing BatchNorm is thus necessary but not sufficient: it prevents the statistics from manufacturing apparent forgetting, and simultaneously makes the weights depend on them. Section 6.5 puts this attribution to an interventional test: keeping the statistics consistent with the weights throughout unlearning removes the vulnerability.

The GroupNorm backbone removes the mechanism by construction—there are no batch statistics to recalibrate—at a cost of 2.0pp of test accuracy (Table 12). The ViT-B/16 backbone (§F.7) does the same for a different reason: LayerNorm normalises per example at inference and keeps no running statistics either. Two architectures with unrelated designs are both outside the operator's reach, and both unlearn properly, which locates the defect in the normalisation scheme rather than in gradient projection.

We state the limit of that plainly: neither backbone *resists* the attack, because the attack is undefined on them. This is a design change, not demonstrated robustness, and a method that must avoid BatchNorm to be safe is constrained in a way the guarantee itself does not capture. What the two rows do establish is that the defect is separable from EXCISE's mechanism—it is a property of freezing statistics that a normalisation layer keeps, and it disappears wherever there are no such statistics. The next subsection removes the constraint itself: it keeps BatchNorm, and makes EXCISE robust to the attack rather than outside its reach.

F.6 BN-robust Excise in Detail

The diagnosis above points at its own remedy: if the weights learn to forget against statistics that are allowed to go stale, the statistics should never be stale. BN-robust EXCISE makes three changes to Algorithm 1 (Figure 7). It leaves the update rule untouched, so Theorem 1 holds at every step for the retain objective under the statistics in force during that step; the recalibration between steps is not covered by it.

1. *Track the weights.* Before every step the BatchNorm statistics are recomputed, $\phi \leftarrow R(\theta, B_r)$, with the attacker's own operator R (`update_bn`) on a fresh sample B_r of 512 retain images. The step's forward and backward passes then run under statistics consistent with the current weights. Forget batches still never touch the statistics: this keeps the half of freezing that was right and drops the half that was wrong.

2. *Ship consistent statistics.* After the last step, $\phi \leftarrow R(\theta_T, \mathcal{D}_r)$ on the whole retain set under test-time transforms—exactly what the attacker computes.

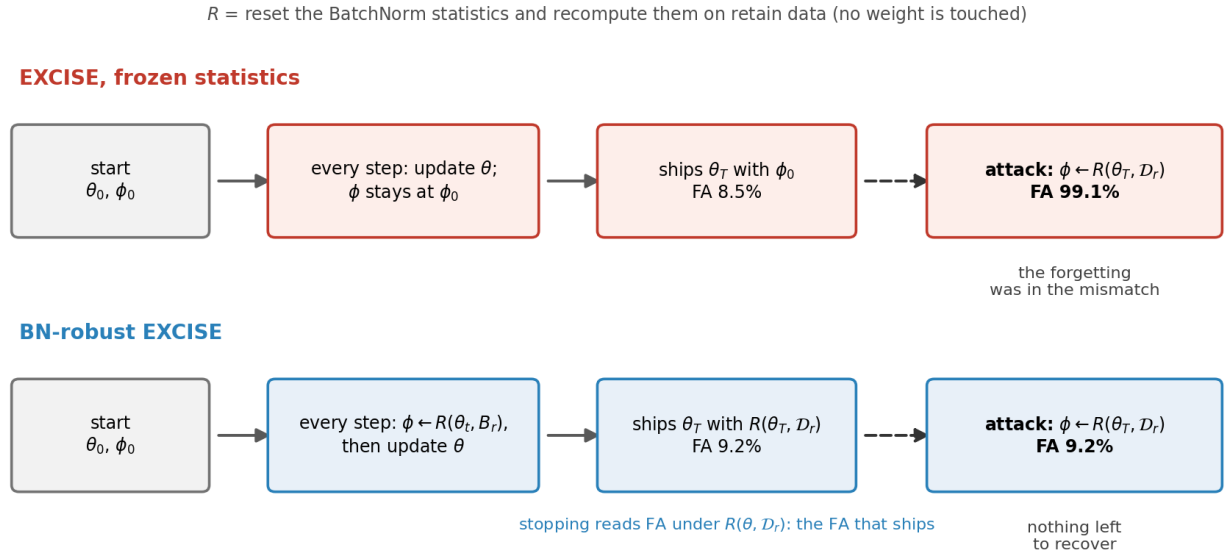


Figure 7: **What BN-robust Excise changes.** R resets the BatchNorm statistics and recomputes them on retain data without touching a weight. With frozen statistics the forgetting lives in the mismatch between θ_T and ϕ_0, and the attack removes it; BN-robust ships statistics consistent with its weights, so the attack has nothing to recover. Forget accuracies are CIFAR-10 class 0, means over three seeds (Table 7).

3. *Stop on the forget accuracy that ships.* The stopping rule of §4.3 reads FA under $R(\theta, \mathcal{D}_r)$ with test-time transforms, not under the in-loop statistics. If the target is not met within the epoch budget, the epoch with the lowest such FA inside the retain budget is shipped instead of the last one.

Because R is idempotent, change 2 makes the attack a no-op on the shipped model by construction, so $\Delta F = 0$ is not by itself evidence here. The question this variant must answer is whether FA is still low once ϕ cannot be stale. Two of the tests below are not no-ops by construction: the exponential-average operator, and recalibration on data other than the retain set.

Change 3 is not cosmetic. Without it, the FA that triggers stopping is read under the in-loop statistics—a few hundred augmented images, one step behind—on augmented forget images. On CIFAR-10 that reading falls short of the shipped FA by between -1.0 and $+9.0$pp depending on the class, and runs stopped at "FA $\leq$ 10%" shipped at 7.2–16.7% (Figure 8). With change 3 the shipped FA meets the target, and the seed-to-seed spread on class 0 falls from 1.90 to 0.08pp (Table 7). The stopping check need not use the whole retain set. Computing it on 10,240 images reproduced every stopping decision of the full check on all three seeds and cut wall-clock by 16%; the shipped statistics still use the full set.

These experiments were run after the checkpoints behind Table 6 became unavailable. They use an earlier CIFAR-10 base (test accuracy 93.97%, against 95.5% there), a GroupNorm base retrained for 100 rather than 200 epochs (91.89%), and a retrained MNIST base (99.59%). Their absolute numbers are therefore not comparable row for row with the rest of §6; every comparison below is between arms that share a base.

It survives the attack it was built against, and two it was not. Calibrated BN-robust forgets class 0 to 9.19% and stays at 9.18% under recalibration (Figure 4a), while the frozen configuration returns to 99.12% with test accuracy back at 94.1%—the original model. The exponential-average operator, which is not idempotent and therefore not a no-op here, moves BN-robust by at most +0.3pp. Nor does robustness depend on the attacker using the retain set. On the naive-stopping checkpoints, recomputing the statistics on the full training set, forget class included, or on the test set—data BN-robust never trained under—moves

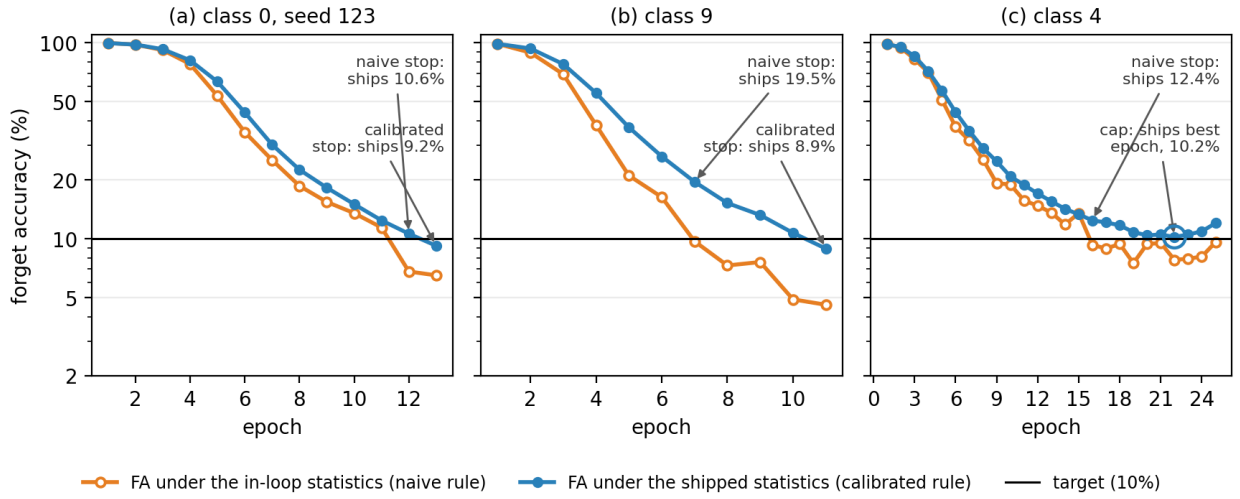


Figure 8: **Why stopping must be calibrated.** Forget accuracy per epoch under the in-loop statistics (what naive stopping reads) and under the statistics that ship (what calibrated stopping reads); log scale. The in-loop reading runs below the shipped one, so a naive rule stops early and ships above chance: (a) one epoch early on class 0, (b) four epochs early on class 9, shipping 19.5% instead of 8.9%. (c) On class 4 the shipped FA plateaus just above 10% and the run reaches the epoch cap; the best-epoch rule ships epoch 22 (10.2%) rather than the last (12.0%).

its FA by −1.0 to −1.2pp, towards more forgetting, while the frozen configuration still recovers to 97.4% and 97.3% (Figure 4b).

Every class, and a second dataset. On all ten CIFAR-10 classes (seed 42; Table 22 and Figure 12), the frozen configuration recovers to 94.7–99.3% under the attack, while BN-robust's FA moves by at most 0.06pp under either stopping rule. With calibrated stopping every class ships between 6.7% and 10.2%, inside three standard errors of chance (11.3% for 5,000 images); with naive stopping, five of the ten did not. One class needed the fallback. Class 4 hovered at 10.2–10.9% for six epochs without crossing 10% and reached the epoch cap, and the rule shipped its best epoch (10.2%) rather than the last (11.9%, with retain accuracy 1.4pp lower). On MNIST, over three seeds, the frozen configuration's forgetting is undone completely (0.00% → 99.97%, with test accuracy back to 99.56% against the base's 99.59%), and BN-robust holds (3.78% → 3.87%, test accuracy 90.10%).

What it costs, and why it is slower. Against the frozen configuration, BN-robust gives up 1.8pp of retain accuracy and 0.9pp of test accuracy and takes about seven times the wall-clock, most of it because it needs 13 epochs instead of 2. We read the slower forgetting as the substance rather than the overhead. The frozen configuration reaches its target in two epochs largely through the statistics mismatch, which the attack shows is not forgetting at all; once the statistics track the weights, the forgetting has to happen in the weights. BN-robust's test accuracy, 84.30%, is close to the 84.6% expected from removing one class of ten from a 93.97% model. Against GroupNorm, BN-robust keeps 1.2pp more test accuracy, mostly because it can start from the stronger BatchNorm base, and it needs neither a change of architecture nor a retrained base model. Membership-inference AUROC stays between 0.48 and 0.52 for every unlearned row.

What it does and does not establish. Unlike GroupNorm or a transformer, this is robustness rather than immunity by construction: the attack is defined on the model, runs, and finds nothing to recover. It is robustness to one attack, though. BN-robust changes only how the normalisation statistics are maintained, so it does nothing against attacks that modify the weights, such as fine-tuning recovery (§7), and we have tested it on two datasets rather than six. Within that scope, Excise no longer has to choose between

Table 13: **ViT-B/16 against ResNet-18**, same algorithm and forget targets as Table 3; the ViT runs check forget accuracy every step. Chance is 10% on CIFAR-10 and 1% on CIFAR-100. The projection fires on 98–100% of steps, as it does on ResNet-18.

Backbone	TA	FA↓	RA	MIA
CIFAR-10, class 0, three seeds				
ResNet-18 (Table 3)	86.13 ± 0.02	1.87 ± 0.25	100.00 ± 0.00	0.529
ViT-B/16	87.05 ± 0.09	9.71 ± 0.27	97.55 ± 0.10	0.453
CIFAR-100, classes $10, \ldots, 90$*, one seed each, 20-epoch cap*				
ResNet-18 (Table 3)	76.17 ± 0.86	4.07 ± 5.51	92.19 ± 0.84	0.500
ViT-B/16	81.97 ± 0.66	24.00 ± 23.16	91.86 ± 0.73	0.435

BatchNorm and its forgetting: BN-robust Excise, Excise with GroupNorm, and Excise on a transformer are all configurations we would deploy.

F.7 A Transformer Backbone

Every result so far uses ResNet-18, so the projection has only ever been applied to a convolutional network. We repeat CIFAR-10 class 0 on ViT-B/16 under the identical algorithm, with representation erasure disabled as everywhere else, over three seeds.

On CIFAR-10 forgetting transfers: FA reaches 9.71%, below the 10% chance level, with retain accuracy at 97.55% and test accuracy slightly *above* the ResNet-18 result. The gap in FA against ResNet-18's 1.87% is not a weaker result but a different stopping point—both runs use $\tau_F = 10\%$, and the ViT run halts as soon as it crosses that threshold (epoch 3, mid-epoch), whereas the ResNet-18 run overshoots it. §6 shows that overshoot is an artifact of check granularity rather than a property of either backbone.

On CIFAR-100 it does not transfer within the same 20-epoch cap. On the nine classes of Table 3, ViT-B/16 ends with FA between 4.0% and 82.0% (mean 24.0%) against a 1% chance level, so no class reaches chance, where ResNet-18 ends at 4.07% and reaches chance at 60 epochs. Retain accuracy (91.9%) matches ResNet-18's. We have not tested whether a longer budget closes the gap, as it does for ResNet-18; until then the transformer result holds for CIFAR-10 only.

Two things follow. First, the conflict the projection resolves is not an artifact of convolutional architectures: the projection fires on 99–100% of steps here as well, so forget and retain gradients oppose one another just as routinely in a transformer. Second, and more usefully, ViT normalises with LayerNorm, which computes statistics per example at inference and stores none. It is therefore outside the reach of the recalibration operator of §6.5 for the same structural reason as GroupNorm, but by way of a completely different architecture—which is what makes the pair informative rather than merely repetitive.

F.8 Component Ablation

A component ablation run in the deployed configuration is uninformative here, and the reason is instructive. Under the projected-momentum optimiser every variant reaches the forget-accuracy target inside the first check interval, so dual stopping halts them all after one epoch and each looks equally good: in the upper half of Table 14, removing the projection costs 0.09pp of retain accuracy. That number is an artefact of stopping, not a measurement of what the projection does.

We therefore also run every variant at *equal compute*, with stopping disabled throughout (lower half). The picture inverts.

The projection is what makes unlearning survivable. At equal compute, removing it costs 41.3pp of test accuracy and 47.4pp of retain accuracy: the model collapses to 44.4/52.6 against 85.7/99.98 for the full method. This is the empirical counterpart of Theorem 1, and it is a far larger effect than the

Table 14: **Component ablation** (CIFAR-10 class 0, seed 42). Upper: the deployed configuration, where dual stopping halts every variant after one epoch. Lower: equal compute, 15 epochs, stopping disabled for all variants—the same comparison without the stopping confound. `+rep` and `+gate` re-introduce the two components removed in §4.

	Variant	TA	FA	RA	MIA
stopping on	full EXCISE	86.10	2.14	100.00	0.528
	−KD	85.56	0.80	99.99	0.516
	−projection	84.87	0.78	99.91	0.513
	selective-layer	86.26	3.26	100.00	0.528
	+rep	86.10	2.14	100.00	0.528
	+gate	86.10	2.14	100.00	0.528
	−stopping	85.71	0.00	99.98	0.472
equal compute	full EXCISE	85.70	0.00	99.98	0.472
	−KD	85.66	0.00	99.94	0.475
	−projection	**44.37**	0.00	**52.55**	0.436
	selective-layer	85.76	0.00	99.99	0.469
	+rep	85.74	0.00	99.98	0.473
	+gate	87.16	19.28	100.00	0.539

stopping-confounded comparison suggests. Note also that the two rows disagree about the *sign* of the conclusion—one reports the projection as costless, the other as indispensable—which is why we report both rather than whichever is more favourable.

KD contributes little once compute is equalised. Removing the distillation anchor changes retain accuracy by 0.04pp at equal compute. We previously attributed several points of retain accuracy to it; that is not supported here, and we no longer claim it.

The removed components stay removed. Re-introducing representation erasure reproduces the full method to within 0.04pp on every metric, and re-introducing the entropy gate leaves forget accuracy at 19.3%—above the 10% chance level, i.e. it prevents the method from forgetting. Both were dropped in §4 on the strength of an ablation run under the previous implementation; this re-run confirms the decision under the current one.

F.9 How Hard Must the Constraint Be?

Theorem 2(iv) argues that a soft conflict penalty biases the update without excluding retain-harming steps, and that only a hard constraint makes them unreachable. That is an argument about feasible sets; here we measure what it costs in practice. We interpolate the projection with a strength parameter s: at each conflicting step the update becomes $u_t = v_t - s\,\frac{\langle v_t, g_\mathrm{r}\rangle}{\|g_\mathrm{r}\|^2} g_\mathrm{r}$, so

$$\langle u_t, g_\mathrm{r}\rangle \;=\; (1-s)\,\langle v_t, g_\mathrm{r}\rangle. \tag{17}$$

At $s = 0$ nothing is corrected; at $s = 1$ this is EXCISE. Every intermediate value is a soft penalty—it shrinks the conflicting component without removing it—and by Eq. 17 it leaves $\langle u_t, g_\mathrm{r}\rangle < 0$ whenever the raw update conflicts. All other settings are held fixed, and stopping is disabled so that every variant sees the same compute.

Softening is expensive, and monotonically so. Retain accuracy falls from 99.98% at $s = 1$ to 52.54% at $s = 0$, and test accuracy from 85.71% to 44.35%, monotonically in between. Because forget accuracy is 0.0% at every setting, this is not a privacy–utility trade-off: all five runs forget equally, and they differ only in how much of the retained model they destroy on the way. The $s = 0$ row reproduces the equal-compute −projection ablation of Table 14 from an independent direction.

Table 15: **Projection strength** (CIFAR-10 class 0, equal compute, stopping disabled). $s = 0$ applies no correction, $s = 1$ is the full hard constraint. Forget accuracy is 0.0% throughout, so the runs differ only in collateral damage.

s	residual conflict	TA	FA	RA	MIA
0.00	$1.00\,\langle v_t, g_r\rangle$	44.35	0.0	52.54	0.436
0.25	$0.75\,\langle v_t, g_r\rangle$	67.84	0.0	81.35	0.497
0.50	$0.50\,\langle v_t, g_r\rangle$	78.03	0.0	92.75	0.510
0.75	$0.25\,\langle v_t, g_r\rangle$	82.99	0.0	98.24	0.509
1.00	**0**	**85.71**	0.0	**99.98**	0.472

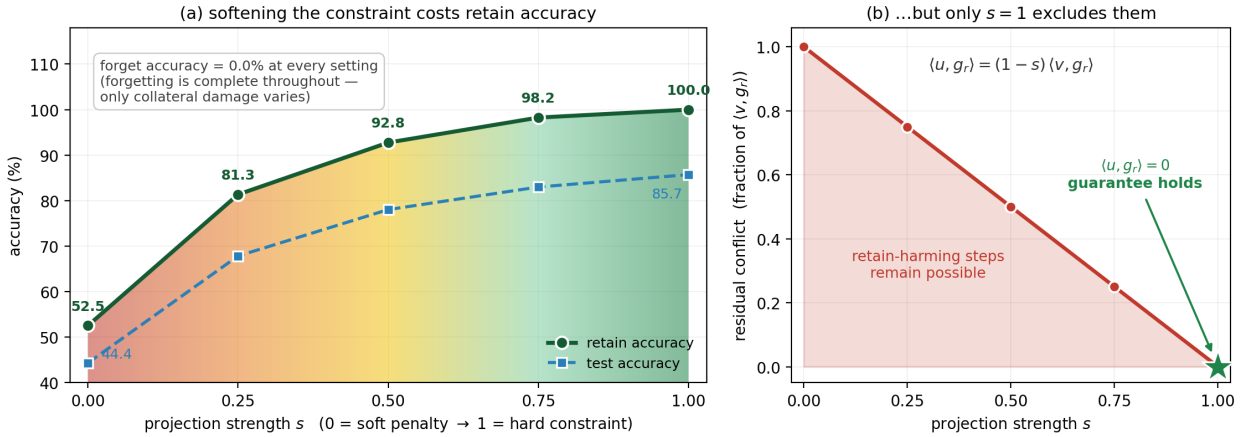


Figure 9: **Hardening the constraint recovers retain accuracy continuously, but only the endpoint carries the guarantee. (a)** Retain and test accuracy against projection strength; forget accuracy is 0.0% at every setting, so the runs differ only in collateral damage. **(b)** Residual conflict $(1 - s)$: retain-harming steps remain reachable for every $s < 1$ and are excluded only at $s = 1$. The empirical difference between $s = 0.75$ and $s = 1$ is 1.7pp of retain accuracy; the difference in what can be proved is categorical.

The curve is gradual, which we take as a limitation of the empirical argument. Most of the benefit arrives early—$s = 0.25$ already recovers 28.8pp of retain accuracy, while the final quarter, $s = 0.75 \to 1$, is worth 1.7pp. A soft penalty tuned near $s = 0.75$ therefore performs almost as well as the hard constraint on these metrics, and we do not claim otherwise. What it does not do is satisfy Eq. 17 with equality: at $s = 0.75$ a quarter of every conflict survives into the applied update, so $\langle u_t, g_r\rangle < 0$ on conflicting steps and no per-step statement can be made. The case for $s = 1$ is therefore not that the last 1.7pp is large, but that it is the only setting about which anything can be proved—which is the whole content of Theorem 1.

Relation to soft conflict-resolution methods. This is a controlled test of the mechanism that separates EXCISE from the closest prior work (Patel & Qiu, 2025), not a comparison with that method: it varies our own projection rather than reimplementing theirs, and their penalty acts on the objective rather than on the update. What it establishes is the general shape of the trade—that discouraging conflict helps in proportion to how much of it is removed, and that removing all of it is what converts an empirical tendency into a guarantee. A like-for-like comparison remains future work (§7).

F.10 Privacy–Utility Frontier and Robustness Diagnostics

We sweep the two tolerances of Eq. 2 independently on CIFAR-10 class 0 (Table 16). The results are asymmetric: one tolerance is inert because the projection has already done its work, while the other is genuinely active but was hidden by how coarsely we measured it.

Table 16: **Tolerance sweeps** (CIFAR-10 class 0). Sweep A varies the retain-loss budget α at fixed $\tau_F = 10\%$; Sweeps B and B′ vary the forget-accuracy target τ_F at fixed $\alpha = 5$, checking forget accuracy every 50 batches and every step respectively. α is inert. So is τ_F under the coarse check—but only because forget accuracy crosses the whole range between two consecutive checks; measured per step, it tracks the requested tolerance across a 29pp range.

Sweep A: α	TA	FA	RA	MIA
1.5	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
2	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
3	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
5	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
10	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
9999	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
Sweep B: τ_F, check every 50 batches	TA	FA	RA	MIA
1%	85.75	0.28	100.00	0.521
5%	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
10%	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
20%	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
30%	86.10	1.88	100.00	0.530
Sweep B′: τ_F, check every step	TA	FA	RA	MIA
1%	85.95	**0.60**	100.00	0.531
5%	86.34	**3.86**	100.00	0.528
10%	86.59	**8.24**	100.00	0.522
20%	87.22	**16.24**	100.00	0.518
30%	88.10	**29.60**	100.00	0.515

The retain budget is non-binding. Varying α over four orders of magnitude changes nothing: the retain-loss constraint is never the active one, because the projection already prevents the retain loss from rising. This is consistent with Theorem 1 and means α can be left at its default.

The forget target is a usable knob, but only if it is measured finely enough. Sweep B contains no frontier: every target from 5% to 30% yields the identical operating point, FA = 1.88%. We previously read this as evidence that τ_F is not a knob at all. That reading was wrong, and Sweep B′ shows why: the sweep was limited by the *measurement*, not by the method.

Forget accuracy is checked every 50 batches, and under this optimiser it falls from ∼99% to below 2% inside a single such interval, so every target in between is passed unobserved and the run halts at whichever point the next check happens to catch. Sweep B′ repeats the sweep with the check evaluated at every step—on a subsample of $\mathcal{D}_f$, with any trigger confirmed on the full forget set before stopping—and the frontier appears: forget accuracy tracks the requested tolerance monotonically from 0.60% to 29.60%, a 29pp range, with test accuracy rising from 85.95% to 88.10% as the tolerance is relaxed and retain accuracy pinned at 100.00% throughout. At $\tau_F = 30\%$ the coarse check lands at FA = 1.88% where 29.60% was reachable: a 27.5pp overshoot attributable entirely to measurement granularity.

Step-level traces confirm that nothing about the collapse forbids resolving it. The largest single-step change in forget accuracy is 11.7–11.9pp across the five targets—the runs follow one trajectory and differ only in where they leave it. A 12pp-per-step descent is comfortably resolvable at per-step granularity; it was invisible at 50-batch granularity. We therefore restore the τ_F entry in Table 1, with the qualification that the tolerance is honoured only when the stopping rule is evaluated at a resolution finer than the descent it is meant to catch. The cost is one forward pass over a 512-sample subsample per step.

Table 17: **Distance to a retrained CIFAR-10 reference** (class 0). The reference is trained on the retain set only. JS and agreement compare output distributions on forget-class inputs; Fréchet compares penultimate features. Best per column in bold. Parameter distance is reported for completeness only (see text).

Method	JS↓	agree %↑	Fréchet↓	$\|\Delta\theta\|_2$	FA	RA	$\|\text{MIA}-0.5\|$ ↓
SalUn	**0.220**	**56.5**	495.3	80.6	0.00	97.70	0.075
Bad Teacher	0.263	47.1	153.0	89.7	24.36	89.46	**0.029**
SCRUB	0.562	8.7	165.9	56.6	89.28	97.83	0.030
EXCISE	0.273	35.2	**13.0**	43.2	1.76	**100.00**	0.030

MIA in isolation is uninformative. An early sign of this: the *pre-unlearning* base model already attains MIA AUROC = 0.533 at FA = 99.7%. For well-generalising classifiers, per-sample membership carries little signal at the class level, so MIA AUROC alone cannot certify class-level unlearning and must be paired with FA. §F.12 develops this into a sharper statement: under the standard protocol the attack scores *higher* against a model that never saw the data than against one that memorised it.

F.11 Distance to a Retrained Model

Forget accuracy asks whether the forget class is still predicted. It does not ask whether the unlearned model *behaves like* one trained without that class, which is what unlearning is for. We therefore retrain a CIFAR-10 reference from scratch on the retain set only, keeping all K output heads so that output distributions remain comparable, and measure how far each unlearned model sits from it (Table 17). Two spaces are measured: the output distribution on forget-class inputs (Jensen–Shannon divergence, and top-1 agreement with the reference's predictions), and the penultimate feature distribution (Fréchet distance).

The two spaces disagree, and no method dominates. EXCISE is closest to the reference in feature space by a wide margin—a Fréchet distance of 13.0 against 153–495 for the baselines, a factor of 38 against SalUn—and it is the only method that leaves retain accuracy untouched. SalUn is closest in output space, with the lowest JS divergence (0.220 against our 0.273) and the highest agreement with the reference's predictions on forget inputs (56.5% against our 35.2%). We report this plainly: on the metric that most directly operationalises "behaves like a retrained model" on forget inputs, EXCISE is second.

The disagreement is itself the finding. A method can route forget-class inputs much as a retrained model would while carrying internal representations far from it, or preserve those representations while routing inputs differently. Reporting a single distance would have concealed this, and which number one reports would have determined which method appeared better. We therefore recommend that distance-to-retrained be reported in both spaces, and we do so.

SCRUB is far away because it has not unlearned. Its JS divergence is more than twice ours and its agreement with the reference is 8.7%, but this follows from FA = 89.3%: a model that still classifies the forget class correctly cannot resemble one that never saw it. This is a useful sanity check on the metric—it ranks non-unlearning last—rather than a criticism of SCRUB under a different operating point.

Parameter distance is uninformative. $\|\Delta\theta\|_2$ orders the methods differently again (43.2 for EXCISE, 56.6 for SCRUB, 80.6 for SalUn, 89.7 for Bad Teacher) and tracks neither behavioural measure. Permutation and scaling symmetries mean two functionally identical networks can sit far apart in parameter space, so we report it for completeness and draw no conclusion from it.

Table 18: **MIA suite on CIFAR-10 (class 0).** Members are forget-class training samples, non-members forget-class test samples (5000 vs 1000). The retrained reference trained on *neither* group, so it is the empirical target; the base model trained on the members and is the opposite anchor. TPR is at 1% FPR.

		loss		mentr		conf		entropy
Model	FA	AUROC	TPR	AUROC	TPR	AUROC	TPR	AUROC
retrained (reference)	0.0	0.694	12.5%	0.646	9.9%	0.435	0.1%	0.422
base (no unlearning)	100.0	0.483	0.0%	0.486	0.0%	0.482	0.0%	0.479
SalUn	0.0	0.500	0.0%	0.537	2.3%	0.463	0.0%	0.461
Bad Teacher	24.8	0.485	0.2%	0.493	0.2%	0.455	0.6%	0.444
SCRUB	89.5	0.477	0.4%	0.478	0.4%	0.467	0.4%	0.462
EXCISE	2.0	0.693	1.4%	0.691	1.3%	0.369	0.0%	0.340

F.12 Membership Inference, Recalibrated

Every MIA number reported so far, in this paper and in much of the unlearning literature, is read against a target of 0.5: the attack should be unable to distinguish forget-class training samples from forget-class test samples. We ran four attacks against a retrained reference to check that target, and it does not survive.

We evaluate four threshold-free signals—negative loss, maximum confidence, negative entropy, and modified entropy (Song & Mittal, 2021), the last of which uses the true label and so separates confidently-correct from confidently-wrong predictions—and report AUROC together with true-positive rate at 1% false-positive rate. The second matters because an attack that identifies a few members with near-certainty is a real privacy failure that an average AUROC of 0.5 can conceal.

The retrained reference does not score 0.5**.** It scores 0.694 on the loss attack, with a true-positive rate of 12.5% at 1% false positives. This model trained on *neither* group: to it, forget train and forget test are both non-members. The attack is therefore not detecting membership. It is detecting that the CIFAR-10 train and test splits of class 0 differ in difficulty, and that difference is visible through any model that has not memorised either. A target of 0.5 is wrong for this protocol, and 0.694 is the level a perfectly unlearned model actually exhibits.

The attack works *better* against the model that never saw the data. The base model memorised all 5000 members and classifies them at 100%; the standard intuition says it should be the most attackable thing in the table. It scores 0.483—below chance, and 0.21 below the retrained reference. A well-generalising classifier treats members and non-members of a class alike, leaving no signal, whereas a model that never saw the class makes errors whose pattern differs between the splits. Under this protocol, MIA AUROC is anti-correlated with memorisation.

The choice of target reverses the ranking. Read against 0.5, EXCISE looks like the *worst* method in the table ($|\text{AUROC} - 0.5| = 0.193$) and SalUn like the best (0.000). Read against the retrained reference—the model unlearning is supposed to imitate—the order inverts: EXCISE is nearest ($|\text{AUROC} - \text{ref}| = 0.001$) and SalUn is 0.194 away. We report both columns rather than the flattering one, and we note that our own earlier claim of "MIA within 0.035 of the ideal 0.5" was resting on the wrong reference point.

We do not want to over-read the agreement between EXCISE and the reference. It is one dataset, one forgotten class, one protocol, and matching to 0.001 is closer than the measurement warrants; what the data supports is that EXCISE sits near the retrained model on this attack while the baselines sit near 0.5, not that it matches it exactly.

On a second dataset the reference is not even a *constant*. The argument above rests on one dataset and one class, which is thin for a claim about everyone's protocol, so we repeated it on PathMNIST, retraining a reference for each of four classes (Table 19). The finding is sharper than we expected. The

Table 19: **MIA on PathMNIST, four classes, each against its own retrained reference.** The reference is the level a perfectly unlearned model exhibits. There is no single such level: it depends on which class was forgotten, and the attacks disagree on direction. Gap is the mean over the four attacks of $|\mathrm{AUROC}_{\textsc{Excise}} - \mathrm{AUROC}_{\mathrm{ref}}|$.

Class	Model	loss	mentr	conf	entropy	gap
0	retrained (reference)	0.704	0.684	0.345	0.344	—
	EXCISE	0.711	0.719	0.305	0.267	**0.040**
2	retrained (reference)	0.306	0.360	0.563	0.571	—
	EXCISE	0.403	0.407	0.187	0.141	0.237
3	retrained (reference)	0.345	0.329	0.666	0.657	—
	EXCISE	0.569	0.597	0.201	0.180	0.359
4	retrained (reference)	0.359	0.366	0.614	0.617	—
	EXCISE	0.589	0.598	0.412	0.410	0.218
reference range across classes		0.398	0.355	0.321	0.312	

reference AUROC is not merely different from 0.5; it moves with the forgotten class, and by a large amount. On the loss attack it ranges from 0.306 (class 2) to 0.704 (class 0), a span of 0.398—wider than the entire distance from 0.5 to either endpoint. The other three attacks span 0.31–0.36 similarly, and reverse direction: on class 0 the reference sits *above* 0.5 for loss and *below* it for confidence, while on classes 2–4 that ordering flips.

This strengthens the diagnosis considerably. It is not that the field uses the wrong constant; it is that no constant is correct. Any protocol that scores unlearning by $|\mathrm{AUROC} - 0.5|$ is comparing against a quantity that varies by up to 0.4 with the choice of forgotten class, so the same method can be judged excellent or poor on the same dataset depending on which class the deletion request happens to name.

Our own matching result does not generalise, and we withdraw the general form of it. The CIFAR-10 agreement above (0.001 on the loss attack) is not reproduced on PathMNIST. EXCISE matches its class-0 reference closely (mean gap 0.040, comparable to CIFAR-10's 0.049), but on classes 2, 3 and 4 the mean gaps are 0.237, 0.359 and 0.218—an average of 0.213 across the four classes, four times the CIFAR-10 figure. EXCISE's own AUROC is comparatively stable across classes while the reference is not, so the method does not track a moving target.

We therefore restrict the claim: on CIFAR-10, and on the class of PathMNIST where the reference resembles CIFAR-10's, EXCISE sits close to the retrained model on loss-based attacks; we do not claim this holds across forgotten classes in general, and the PathMNIST measurements show that it does not. The protocol finding and the method finding should be read separately—the first is strengthened by this experiment, and the second is narrowed by it.

An AUROC of exactly 0.5 can be degenerate. SalUn's loss attack gives 0.5000 with a true-positive rate of 0.0% at every false-positive rate we measured. An uninformative-but-varying score gives TPR $\approx$ FPR, i.e. about 1%; a TPR of zero is the signature of a *constant* score. SalUn maps every forget-class input to the same output, so there is nothing for the attack to rank. This is a way of being unattackable, but it is not evidence of having imitated a retrained model—and reporting AUROC alone cannot tell the two apart. The TPR column can.

Recommendation. For class-level unlearning we recommend that MIA be reported (i) with more than one attack, since the four disagree here even in sign—the reference is above 0.5 on loss and below it on confidence, and that ordering itself flips between PathMNIST classes; (ii) with TPR at a low FPR alongside AUROC, since an AUROC of 0.5 can be produced by a constant score that no attack can rank; (iii) calibrated

against a retrained reference rather than against 0.5; and (iv) *per forgotten class*, against that class's own reference, because Table 19 shows a single reference does not transfer between classes of one dataset.

Point (iv) is expensive—it costs one retraining per class—which is the honest obstacle to the recommendation. Where that is out of reach, we would report MIA as a diagnostic alongside forget accuracy and decline to draw any conclusion from its distance to 0.5, rather than treat 0.5 as a target the measurements do not support.

F.13 Over-Forgetting, and a Fix That Did Not Work

Two PathMNIST classes are over-forgotten: MIA AUROC reaches 0.298 and 0.388, i.e. forget-class training samples become *harder* to classify than forget-class test samples. Such a model is still distinguishable from a retrained one—in the opposite direction to a privacy leak—while satisfying every forget-accuracy check. FA cannot detect this, because moving *to* the distribution a retrained model produces and moving *past* it both give FA ≈ 0.

We hypothesised that the cause was the gap between stating the forget-side condition on distributions, $\mathrm{KL}(p_\theta(x_f)\|p_r) \leq \epsilon$—as an earlier version of Eq. 2 did—and implementing it on the argmax, FA $\leq \tau_F$, as dual stopping does, and that stopping on the divergence instead would fix it. We retrained reference models without the forget class, pre-committed to the prediction, and ran the experiment. **The prediction failed.** Stopping on the divergence was worse on 10 of 12 comparisons, made Jensen–Shannon divergence to the retrained reference worse on all three classes, and degraded an unaffected control class—the signature that rules out a targeted fix. Across checkpoints the proposed criterion is rank-*anti*-correlated with distance to the retrained model ($\rho = -1.00$): driving it toward zero moves the model away from the reference. Appendix J reports the experiment in full, including a limitation of the test itself and a confound we cannot separate.

Two conclusions follow, and we adopt both. First, a narrower reading of the `kl_retain` objective: p_r is a useful forget-side *direction* (§4.3), but it is not what a retrained model produces on forget inputs, and minimising the divergence to it is actively harmful. This is why Eq. 2 states the forget condition as a target met at the end of the search, with the divergence only as its direction, rather than as an objective to be driven to its minimum. Second, the experiment localised a different and more mundane cause: all three FA-stopped runs overshoot their own 11.1% target by ∼4pp because the intra-epoch FA check is evaluated only every 50 batches, and divergence to the retrained model is lower at the earlier stopping point in every class. The indicated fix is to stop earlier and more precisely rather than to replace the stopped quantity.

That fix is now implemented and it works. Evaluating the check at every step rather than every 50 batches removes the overshoot on CIFAR-10 and recovers a monotonic frontier over a 29pp range of forget accuracy (§6, Sweep B′ of Table 16); the descent it must resolve is ∼12pp per step, which is well within reach at that granularity. The mechanism is shared, so we expect the same remedy to reduce the PathMNIST overshoot, but we have not re-run the over-forgotten classes under the finer check and do not claim the over-forgetting defect itself is resolved. What has changed is its status: it is a consequence of measuring the stopping criterion too coarsely, not evidence that the criterion is the wrong one. The remaining question—where along the trajectory divergence to the retrained model is minimised, and whether a single FA level identifies it across classes—stays open.

F.14 Locating the Stopping Point, and What MIA Cannot Tell Us

The refuted hypothesis of §F.13 left a concrete question: if stopping on the forget-side divergence is not the fix, *where* should unlearning stop? We answer it by measuring the whole trajectory rather than comparing two rules. For PathMNIST classes 2, 3 (over-forgotten) and 4 (control), we run unlearning with stopping disabled, snapshot the weights every 8 optimiser steps, and evaluate each snapshot against a retrained reference (Appendix J). Figure 10 shows the result.

The minimum is interior, and the current rule is past it. Divergence to the reference falls from 0.66–0.69 at initialisation to 0.28–0.38, then rises again to 0.40–0.42. So unlearning genuinely moves the model toward a retrained one before moving away: over-forgetting is not a metric artefact but a real overshoot in

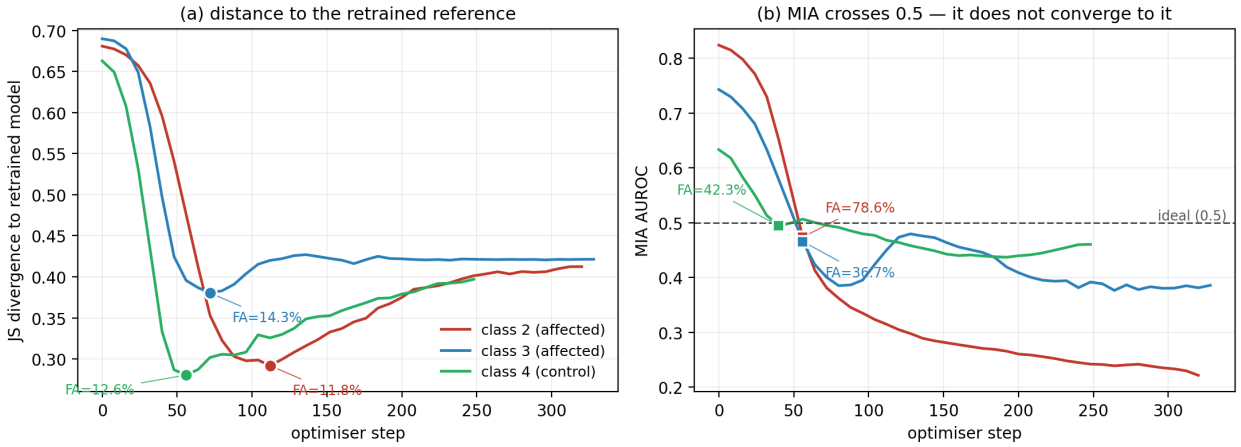


Figure 10: **Unlearning overshoots the model it is trying to imitate, and MIA cannot detect it. (a)** Jensen–Shannon divergence to a retrained-from-scratch reference along the unlearning trajectory. The curve is U-shaped: the model first moves toward the reference, attains a minimum, then moves away. Markers give the minimum, annotated with the forget accuracy there (11.8–14.3%)—*above* the 11.1% chance level, whereas dual stopping halts at ≈7%. **(b)** MIA AUROC on the same axis. It sweeps *through* the ideal 0.5 rather than converging to it, so $|\text{MIA} - 0.5|$ is minimised at the crossing. On class 2 that crossing occurs while the model still classifies 78.6% of the forget set correctly.

function space. The minimum lies at FA = 11.8%, 14.3% and 12.6% for the three classes, while dual stopping halts at ≈7% (§F.13) — past the optimum in every case. Stopping at the minimum instead is close to free: test accuracy changes by −0.06, −0.03 and +0.79pp and retain accuracy by +0.06, +0.36 and +0.08pp. On the same trajectory it reduces divergence by 0.016, 0.003 and 0.007, and reduces $|\text{MIA} - 0.5|$ by 0.017 and 0.015 on the two affected classes while moving the control by +0.006. This is the pattern the criterion of §F.13 failed to produce: the affected classes improve and the control stays put.

But the optimum is shallow, so we do not propose a numeric target. The three minima fall within 2.5pp of one another in forget accuracy, which invites the conclusion that "stop at FA ≈ 13%" is a deployable rule. The basin does not support that reading. Taking every checkpoint within 5% of the minimum divergence, the corresponding forget accuracy spans 10.2–26.3%, 3.5–36.7% and 6.9–21.9% on the three classes—3.5–36.7% overall. The agreement between the three *argmin* values is therefore largely a coincidence of where the snapshots happened to land, and a single tuned number would not transfer. What the data does support is directional and, we think, more useful: the optimum sits *above* the chance level, and a rule that drives forget accuracy to or below chance is on the wrong side of it.

$|\text{MIA} - 0.5|$ is not an optimisation target. Panel (b) is the more consequential finding. MIA AUROC does not converge to 0.5; it *passes through* it, falling from 0.82, 0.74 and 0.63 at initialisation to 0.22, 0.39 and 0.46 at the end. Consequently $|\text{MIA} - 0.5|$ is minimised wherever the trajectory happens to cross, which carries no information about unlearning quality. On class 2 the crossing occurs at FA = 78.6%: a model that has barely forgotten anything attains a *perfect* MIA score. The two criteria also disagree about where to stop, and in opposite directions—the divergence minimum and the MIA minimum are 56 steps apart on class 2, 56 steps apart the other way on class 3, and 8 steps apart on class 4.

This sharpens the observation of §6 that a pre-unlearning model already scores MIA = 0.533. That was a single point; here we see the whole path, and it shows that MIA ≈ 0.5 is attainable at almost any stage of unlearning, including stages with no meaningful forgetting at all. Reporting MIA alongside forget accuracy is therefore not merely advisable but necessary, and *optimising* $|\text{MIA} - 0.5|$—which a practitioner reading "ideal = 0.5" might reasonably attempt—selects an arbitrary point on the trajectory.

What remains unresolved. Stopping at the divergence minimum reduces over-forgetting without eliminating it: class 2 still attains MIA = 0.315 there, far from 0.5. Nor do we have a deployable rule, since locating the minimum requires the retrained reference that unlearning exists to avoid, and the basin is too flat for a fixed forget accuracy to stand in for it. We report the diagnosis—the stopping rule halts on the wrong side of a real optimum—and leave a practical criterion open. Whether the effect holds beyond the three PathMNIST classes measured here is also untested; the experiment costs one unlearning run plus one retrained reference per class.

G Limitations in Full

Compute scales with classes and with data scarcity, and we cannot predict it. At its 15-epoch cap EXCISE leaves STL-10 at FA = 75.7%, and an earlier version of this paper reported that as a failure mode of the hard constraint on small forget sets. That diagnosis was wrong in its conclusion though right about its cause. With 500 training images per class the forget set yields only 4 mini-batches per epoch, ∼60 update steps in total, and every step conflicts with the retain gradient—so progress per step is small and the budget expires before forgetting completes. At 60 epochs, over the same three seeds and with a per-step check and a 1% target, FA falls to $1.73 \pm 0.95\%$ with RA = 98.87% (with the default 10% target a single 60-epoch run stops at 9.2%). CIFAR-100 behaves the same way for a different reason: its per-class forget sets are small because there are a hundred of them, and at 60 epochs its nine-class mean falls from 4.07% to $1.27 \pm 0.39\%$, bringing the 1% chance level inside one standard deviation. Neither constraint was infeasible; both runs were truncated.

What survives as a limitation is that we cannot say in advance how much budget a new dataset needs. The binding resource is optimiser steps rather than epochs or examples, and EXCISE offers no way to predict the requirement beyond monitoring forget accuracy and continuing until the tolerance is met. A practitioner deploying on an unfamiliar dataset should expect to discover the budget empirically, and should treat a shared epoch count copied from another dataset as a likely under-estimate.

Sample-level forgetting works, but at a cost the method cannot control. Every result in this paper removes a whole class. We tested the other standard request type—forgetting a random subset of training points—on CIFAR-10 at 1% and 5% of the training set, and report it as a scope limit rather than a capability.

Two things go wrong, and they are different in kind. First, the forget objective degenerates. `kl_retain` draws its power from the forget class being *absent* from the retain set, which drives p_r's mass on that class to ∼0 (measured: 0.0002); when the forget set is a random subset, the retain set still covers every class and p_r is uniform to three decimals $(0.100, 0.100, \dots)$. `kl_retain` therefore reduces exactly to `kl_uniform` in this regime, and the target carries no information about *which* points to forget. Second, dual stopping does not fire: the retain budget is multiplicative on an initial retain loss of 0.0018, so even at $\alpha = 100$ both stopping-armed runs halted on the budget with forget accuracy still at ∼99.5%. A multiplicative budget is the wrong instrument against a converged model; an absolute floor would be the right one.

Given a fixed 60-epoch budget and no stopping, forgetting does occur—forget accuracy falls to 58.4% at 1% and 71.8% at 5%—but indiscriminately: retain accuracy falls from ∼100% to 73.2% and test accuracy to 71.9%, and forget accuracy ends *below* test accuracy, which is over-forgetting by the standard for this setting (a correctly unlearned point should look like an unseen point of the same class, i.e. FA ≈ TA). The method has no mechanism to stop at that crossing.

The one clearly positive finding is the ablation. Removing the projection at equal budget collapses the model completely: retain accuracy 14.2% versus 73.2% with it, and test accuracy 17.1% versus 71.9%—a 59pp and 55pp difference respectively, far larger than the projection's effect in the class-level ablation of Table 14. When forget and retain gradients are drawn from the same distribution the conflict is near-total (the projection fires on 100% of steps), and the retain constraint is the only thing keeping the model intact. The guarantee is therefore *more* load-bearing here, not less—which is why we regard sample-level forgetting as a direction the constraint supports and the objective does not yet.

Mini-batch scope of the guarantee. Theorem 1 bounds the *sampled* retain objective—the quantity EXCISE projects against—not the full-population retain loss. A population-exact per-step guarantee would require controlling the gradient-variance term and is future work.

The comparison with the closest prior work is structural, not empirical. Our separation from soft conflict-resolution methods (Patel & Qiu, 2025) rests on Theorem 2(iv) and Table 1, both of which argue from the definition of the update rule. We have not reimplemented that method and run it on our stack, so we make no claim about how the two compare on accuracy, forgetting, or MIA. A like-for-like empirical comparison is the most important piece of missing evidence in this paper. Two related experiments are reported and should not be mistaken for it: the projection-only ablation, isolating the projection from EXCISE's other three components (Table 4), and the projection-strength sweep, which interpolates our own update between a soft penalty and the hard constraint (§F.9). Both test the mechanism; neither runs the cited method.

Floating-point exactness. The guarantee holds to float32 precision (§F.4); exact arithmetic would require float64 inner products.

BatchNorm robustness is bought with compute, and is scoped. BN-robust EXCISE (§6.5) survives the recalibration attack at about seven times the wall-clock of the default configuration, because forgetting that has to happen in the weights takes more steps. It was evaluated on two datasets, CIFAR-10 (every class) and MNIST, and on base models that differ from those behind the rest of the paper. It also defends only the normalisation statistics: an attacker who modifies weights, as in the fine-tuning recovery below, is outside what it changes.

Sequential unlearning and fine-tuning recovery. *Sequential unlearning*: forgetting classes 0, then 1, then 2 from each resulting checkpoint takes test accuracy 86.1 → 76.8 → 69.1 and retain accuracy 100.0 → 89.7 → 80.7, with forget accuracy on the newest class at most 2.7%. The decline is what forgetting does to these metrics, not damage. TA counts every forgotten class's test images as errors, so fully forgotten classes alone take it to 0.9, 0.8 and 0.7 times the retained-class accuracy (with the base model's 95.5%: 86.0, 76.4 and 66.9%); RA is measured on a retain set that still contains the earlier-forgotten classes, so fully forgotten classes take it to at most 8/9 and 7/9 (88.9% and 77.8%). The observed values sit at or above these levels, so the retained classes are not damaged cumulatively. They sit above them because earlier-forgotten classes partly return: an RA of 80.7% requires the two earlier classes to average at least 13% training accuracy, above the 10% chance level. A sequential deployment should therefore re-check every forgotten class after each request. *Fine-tuning recovery*: retraining the unlearned model on 50 forget-class samples raises forget accuracy from 1.9% to 7.1% after five epochs and 51.3% after ten—though by then the model is no longer usable (TA = 34.6%, RA = 47.9%), so the attack recovers the class only by destroying the model it attacks. EXCISE also does not provide formal (ε, δ)-DP guarantees.

H Per-Class Results

The main text reports per-dataset aggregates (Table 3). Because a mean over classes can conceal a method that succeeds on easy classes and fails on hard ones, we report every class individually. Each row is the mean ± standard deviation over seeds $\{42, 123, 456\}$. CIFAR-100 per-class results appear in the main text (Table 10); the raw per-run CSVs for all 75 runs are released with the code.

H.1 MNIST (all 10 classes)

Table 20 gives all ten MNIST classes. Every class individually falls below the 10% chance level, with per-class mean FA ranging from 1.89% (class 1) to 9.42% (class 7); the aggregate is therefore not concealing a failure. Retain accuracy is essentially constant across classes (99.42–99.54%), and MIA stays within 0.017 of the ideal 0.5 for every class. Seed variance is small throughout (the largest FA standard deviation across classes is 0.89pp), indicating the procedure is stable rather than seed-lucky.

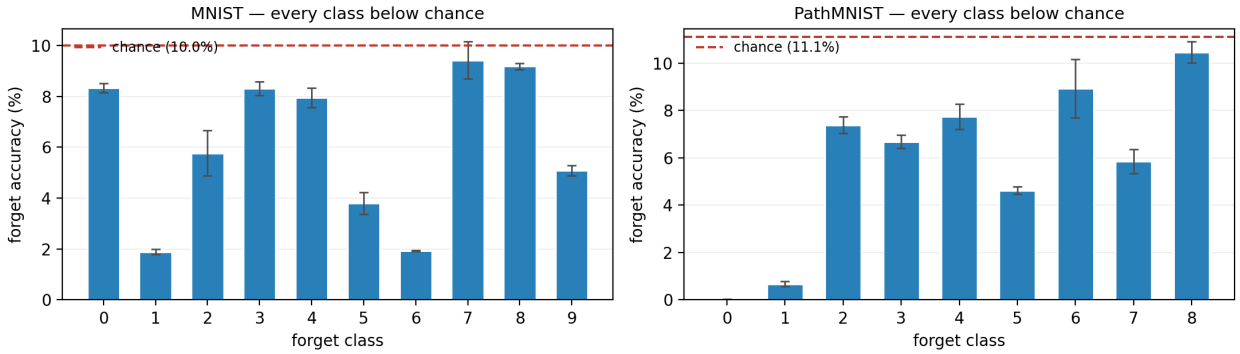


Figure 11: **Per-class forget accuracy** (mean ± std over three seeds). Every MNIST and PathMNIST class individually falls below its chance level, so the per-dataset means of Table 3 are not concealing a class that fails.

Table 20: **MNIST per-class forgetting** (mean ± std over 3 seeds). Chance level is 10.0%; every class attains FA below it. TA is measured on the full test set, so it necessarily drops by ∼10pp relative to the 99% base model once the forget class is correctly no longer recognised.

Forget class	TA (%)	FA (%)↓	RA (%)	MIA
0	90.26 ± 0.05	8.33 ± 0.18	99.42 ± 0.00	0.495 ± 0.002
1	88.29 ± 0.01	1.89 ± 0.09	99.50 ± 0.02	0.512 ± 0.001
2	89.68 ± 0.07	5.77 ± 0.89	99.51 ± 0.01	0.491 ± 0.001
3	90.37 ± 0.02	8.31 ± 0.27	99.45 ± 0.01	0.483 ± 0.001
4	90.22 ± 0.01	7.95 ± 0.39	99.43 ± 0.02	0.510 ± 0.001
5	90.76 ± 0.04	3.80 ± 0.43	99.52 ± 0.03	0.499 ± 0.001
6	90.08 ± 0.02	1.92 ± 0.03	99.50 ± 0.02	0.501 ± 0.001
7	90.03 ± 0.03	9.42 ± 0.74	99.51 ± 0.01	0.490 ± 0.000
8	90.36 ± 0.03	9.19 ± 0.13	99.50 ± 0.02	0.486 ± 0.001
9	89.97 ± 0.05	5.09 ± 0.21	99.54 ± 0.02	0.503 ± 0.000
Mean	**90.00**	**6.17**	**99.49**	**0.497**

H.2 PathMNIST (all 9 classes)

Table 21 gives all nine PathMNIST tissue classes. Every class again falls below the 11.1% chance level, from 0.02% (class 0) to 10.46% (class 8). Two observations deserve stating explicitly rather than being averaged away.

First, the spread is far wider than on MNIST—per-class TA ranges from 73.23% to 89.28%—reflecting genuinely unequal class difficulty in histopathology rather than instability: within-class seed variance remains small (largest FA standard deviation 1.23pp).

Second, and more importantly, **MIA AUROC is not uniformly near** 0.5: class 2 reaches 0.298 and class 3 0.388, both well *below* the ideal. A value substantially below 0.5 indicates that forget-class training samples have become *harder* to classify than forget-class test samples—the signature of *over*-forgetting, in which the unlearned model is distinguishable from a retrained one in the opposite direction to a privacy leak. It is detectable precisely because we report MIA per class and treat distance from 0.5 in either direction as a defect. We flag this as a real limitation of the current stopping rule on PathMNIST: dual stopping targets FA, which does not constrain how far past the retrained model's output statistics the optimiser travels.

On the per-dataset MIA aggregate. The PathMNIST aggregate of 0.483 ± 0.084 in Table 3 is within 0.017 of ideal, but its standard deviation is an order of magnitude larger than any other dataset's precisely

Table 21: **PathMNIST per-class forgetting** (mean ± std over 3 seeds). Chance level is 11.1%; every class attains FA below it. †Classes 2 and 3 show MIA well below the ideal 0.5, indicating over-forgetting (see text).

Forget class	TA (%)	FA (%)↓	RA (%)	MIA
0	73.23 ± 0.06	0.02 ± 0.02	99.01 ± 0.01	0.511 ± 0.003
1	78.66 ± 0.26	0.68 ± 0.12	98.48 ± 0.08	0.473 ± 0.003
2†	89.28 ± 0.12	7.38 ± 0.35	99.02 ± 0.02	0.298 ± 0.003
3†	82.40 ± 0.12	6.68 ± 0.28	98.86 ± 0.02	0.388 ± 0.005
4	78.04 ± 0.08	7.73 ± 0.53	98.95 ± 0.03	0.502 ± 0.001
5	84.58 ± 0.03	4.62 ± 0.15	98.32 ± 0.02	0.548 ± 0.001
6	78.58 ± 0.25	8.93 ± 1.23	98.77 ± 0.06	0.541 ± 0.001
7	88.48 ± 0.14	5.85 ± 0.50	99.25 ± 0.01	0.562 ± 0.001
8	75.36 ± 0.04	10.46 ± 0.45	99.28 ± 0.03	0.525 ± 0.001
Mean	**80.96**	**5.82**	**98.88**	**0.483**

Table 22: **BN-robust Excise per class** (CIFAR-10, seed 42). The frozen-statistics configuration is recovered on every class. BN-robust is not, under either stopping rule, and with calibrated stopping every class ships within three standard errors of chance (11.3%). Epochs "25→22": the run reached the cap and its best epoch was shipped.

	Frozen		BN-robust, naive		BN-robust, calibrated				
Class	pre	post	pre	post	pre	post	epochs	TA	RA
0	8.76	99.22	9.24	9.28	9.22	9.24	13	84.35	95.60
1	2.40	97.60	10.66	10.66	6.66	6.66	8	84.56	96.19
2	6.52	98.30	11.18	11.16	9.90	9.92	15	85.07	95.27
3	4.78	94.82	11.30	11.30	10.00	9.98	16	85.92	96.26
4	4.84	97.34	13.32	13.34	10.18	10.16	25→22	84.88	94.74
5	7.28	94.70	8.78	8.78	9.40	9.42	12	84.52	94.64
6	9.18	99.14	7.20	7.20	7.30	7.30	8	83.32	94.41
7	3.38	96.20	11.36	11.34	9.12	9.12	10	84.49	95.24
8	4.54	99.26	16.74	16.68	9.74	9.68	14	83.59	94.67
9	2.52	98.16	15.44	15.42	8.92	8.92	11	83.84	95.01
Mean	5.42	97.47	11.52	11.52	9.04	9.04	—	84.45	95.20

because of classes 2 and 3. The aggregate is accurate but uninformative here; this is a concrete instance of the more general point of §6 that MIA must be read alongside FA, and per-class rather than only in aggregate.

H.3 BN-robust Excise on all ten CIFAR-10 classes

Table 22 gives every CIFAR-10 class under the recalibration attack of §6.5, one seed per class (class 0 has three seeds in Table 7). "Pre" and "post" are FA under test-time transforms before and after `update_bn` on the retain set. All runs share the 93.97% base of §6.5. The calibrated runs here read the stopping FA on the full retain set rather than the 10,240-image subset; on class 0 the two made identical stopping decisions (§6.5).

I Hyperparameter Configuration

Table 23 lists the settings shared across all datasets and Table 24 the per-dataset settings. All are released as YAML configuration files; the reported runs use them unmodified.

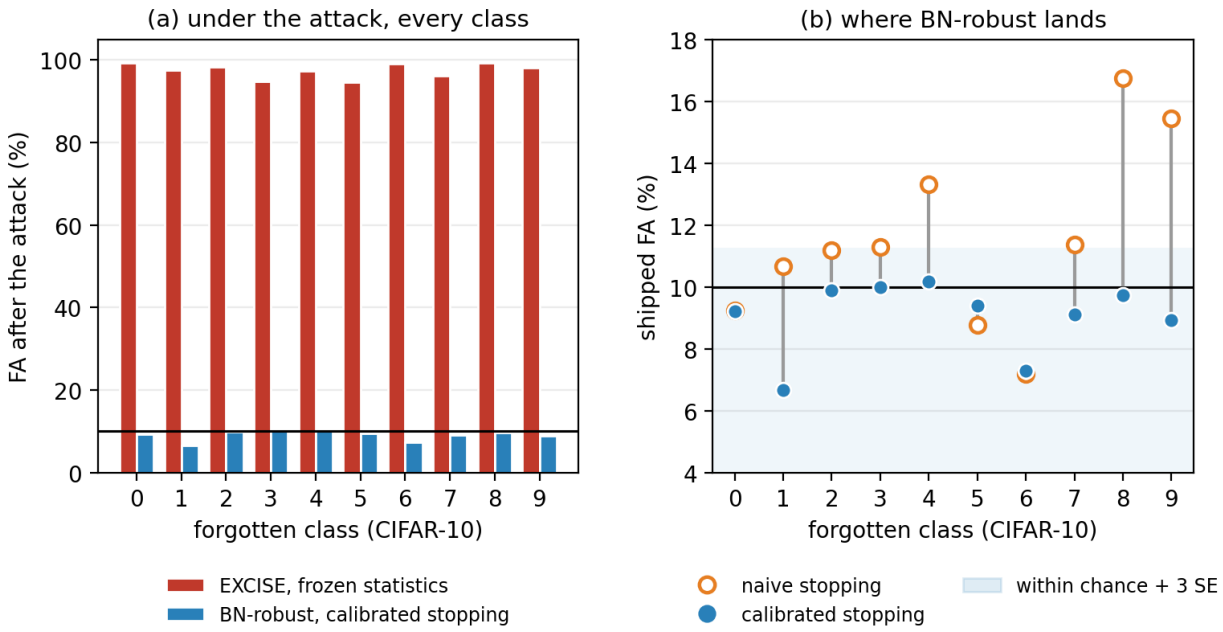


Figure 12: **BN-robust on all ten CIFAR-10 classes** (seed 42; the data of Table 22). (a) Under the attack, the frozen-statistics configuration is recovered on every class and BN-robust on none. (b) Where BN-robust ships: with naive stopping (open) five classes land above chance + 3 SE; with calibrated stopping (filled), none do.

Table 23: **Shared hyperparameters** (identical for all six datasets). The two components removed from EXCISE are listed explicitly with value 0, since they remain available as flags for the ablation of §F.8.

Symbol	Flag	Value	Role
μ	`-momentum`	0.9	momentum; projection applied *after* accumulation
c	`-max_grad_norm`	1.0	clip on d_t, *before* accumulation
λ_{wd}	`-weight_decay`	5×10^{-4}	weight decay, applied inside d_t
T_{KD}	`-temperature`	4.0	distillation temperature
—	`-forget_objective`	`kl_retain`	KL toward retain-confusion p_r
—	`-batch_size`	128	forget and retain mini-batch size
—	`-fa_check_freq`	50	intra-epoch FA check interval (batches)
—	`-seed`	$\{42, 123, 456\}$	three seeds per task
Removed components (retained as ablation flags only)			
λ	`-rep_weight`	0.0	representation erasure (removed)
γ	`-forget_gate`	0.0	entropy gate (removed)

Tuning effort. Only four quantities vary across datasets: the epoch cap T, the learning rate η, the KD weight β, and the retain budget α. The learning rate takes one of two values (5×10^{-4} for the CIFAR datasets, 2×10^{-4} elsewhere), β one of three, and α one of two. The forget target τ_F is not tuned at all: it is fixed to the chance level $100/K$ implied by the task. Notably, μ, c, λ_{wd}, and T_{KD}—the four quantities that enter the guarantee of Theorem 3—are held constant across all six datasets, so the bound $\frac{1}{2}L\eta^2(c/(1-\mu))^2$ varies across datasets only through η (and through the dataset-dependent smoothness constant L).

A note on defaults. The command-line default for `-max_grad_norm` in the released code is 5.0, whereas every configuration file sets $c = 1.0$. Runs launched without `-config` would therefore use a different clip threshold, and a correspondingly weaker constant in (16). All results in this paper use the configuration

Table 24: **Per-dataset hyperparameters.** K is the number of classes. Note that the forget-accuracy target τ_F is set to the chance level $100/K$ for every dataset—it is not tuned per dataset, but derived from the task.

Dataset	K	Epochs T	η	β (KD)	α (retain budget)	$\tau_F = 100/K$
CIFAR-10	10	15	5×10^{-4}	2.0	5.0	10.0%
CIFAR-100	100	20	5×10^{-4}	2.0	5.0	1.0%
MNIST	10	12	2×10^{-4}	3.0	4.0	10.0%
SVHN	10	15	2×10^{-4}	3.0	5.0	10.0%
STL-10	10	15	2×10^{-4}	5.0	5.0	10.0%
PathMNIST	9	12	2×10^{-4}	5.0	4.0	11.1%

files. We note this because the value of c enters the guarantee directly, so it should not be inherited silently from a default.

J Distance to the Retrained Model: A Refuted Hypothesis

This appendix reports a negative result. We formed a hypothesis about why EXCISE over-forgets on two PathMNIST classes, derived a deployable fix from it, pre-committed to a falsifiable prediction, ran the experiment, and the prediction did not hold. We report it in full because the experiment also produced the diagnosis that we believe is correct, and because the refuted hypothesis concerns EXCISE's own forget objective.

J.1 The defect, and the hypothesis

Per-class reporting (Appendix H) showed that on PathMNIST classes 2 and 3, MIA AUROC reaches 0.298 and 0.388—far *below* the ideal 0.5. Forget accuracy is satisfied on both, so FA alone certifies these runs as successes when they are not. A value below 0.5 means forget-class training samples have become *harder* to classify than forget-class test samples: the model is still distinguishable from a retrained one, in the opposite direction to a privacy leak.

An earlier version of our forget-side condition (Eq. 2) was $\mathrm{KL}(p_\theta(x_f) \,\|\, p_r) \leq \epsilon$, a statement about *distributions*, but dual stopping (§4.3) implements FA $\leq \tau_F$, a statement about *argmax*. These are not equivalent, and we hypothesised that the discrepancy was the cause: FA cannot distinguish (a) $p_\theta(x_f)$ having moved *to* the distribution a retrained model produces from (b) having moved *past* it, since both give FA ≈ 0.

The hypothesised fix was to enforce the constraint as stated. Since p_r is computed from the *original* model, this needs no retrained reference and is deployable: stop on $\mathrm{KL}(p_\theta(x_f) \| p_r)$ rather than on FA. We reasoned that this quantity is minimised at $p_\theta = p_r$ and rises on either side, so a stop-when-it-stops-improving rule would halt at the minimum—exactly the point FA cannot locate.

Prediction (pre-committed). Replacing FA stopping with KL stopping would, on the affected classes, (1) reduce $|\mathrm{MIA} - 0.5|$, (2) reduce Jensen–Shannon divergence to a retrained reference, and (3) not materially worsen FA or RA, while leaving an unaffected control class approximately unchanged.

J.2 Design

We retrained reference models without the forget class for PathMNIST classes 2 and 3 (affected) and class 4 (control, MIA already 0.501), keeping all K output heads so that output distributions remain comparable, and training all three identically for a fixed 30-epoch cosine schedule so that no reference is better converged than another. Arm A is EXCISE with FA stopping (the deployed configuration); arm B disables FA stopping and enables KL stopping. Oracle metrics are computed against the references: JS divergence between output

Table 25: **KL stopping vs. FA stopping on PathMNIST**, measured against retrained references. Arrows mark the direction of improvement. The prediction was that the affected classes would improve and the control would not move; neither held.

Class	Arm	$\lvert\text{MIA}-0.5\rvert \downarrow$	JS↓	agree %↑	Fréchet↓	KL to p_r
2 (affected)	FA stop	0.205	0.308	45.4	185.7	0.957
	KL stop	0.268	0.412	23.5	332.0	0.052
3 (affected)	FA stop	0.115	0.382	31.2	375.2	0.805
	KL stop	**0.068**	0.421	**39.8**	780.1	0.002
4 (control)	FA stop	0.001	0.286	38.7	141.1	1.510
	KL stop	0.044	0.399	12.3	297.7	0.116

distributions on the forget set (primary), top-1 agreement with the reference, Fréchet distance between penultimate features, and MIA.

The control class is the load-bearing part of the design: a criterion that merely stops earlier everywhere would improve the affected classes while also perturbing the control, whereas a targeted fix should leave the control alone.

J.3 Result: the prediction fails

Table 25 reports the outcome. Across three classes and four metrics, arm B is better on 2 comparisons and worse on 10. The primary oracle metric—JS divergence to the retrained model—is *worse in all three classes*. The control class degrades on every metric, which is precisely the signature that rules out a targeted fix. Only class 3 improves on $|\text{MIA} - 0.5|$.

The proxy is anti-correlated with the oracle. A proxy is only usable if it tracks the quantity it stands in for. Across the six checkpoints, the rank correlation between $\text{KL}(p_\theta \| p_r)$ and JS divergence to the retrained model is $\rho = -1.00$ (Pearson -0.94): the ordering is perfectly inverted. Driving the deployable proxy toward zero moves the model monotonically *away* from the retrained reference. This is the opposite of the relationship the hypothesis required.

J.4 Why it failed

(i) The criterion never fired. In all three runs of arm B the terminating condition was the retain-loss budget, not the KL rule. The reason is visible in the logged trajectories: $\text{KL}(p_\theta(x_f) \| p_r)$ decreases essentially monotonically (class 2: $5.53 \to 0.05$ over 8 checks with zero increases; class 4: $2.73 \to 0.07$, zero increases; class 3: $2.06 \to 0.002$ over 20 checks with 4 small increases). It never turns back up, so a stop-when-it-stops-improving rule cannot trigger. The U-shape the hypothesis assumed does not exist over the range the optimiser traverses.

This is also a limitation of the test, and we state it plainly: because the KL rule never fired and FA stopping was disabled, arm B is in effect EXCISE *without forget-side stopping* (FA reaches 0.0 in all three runs), which is closer to the −Stopping ablation than to a KL-stopped method. The comparison in Table 25 is therefore evidence against the criterion *as specified*, not a clean contrast between two stopping rules.

(ii) p_r is a global average; a retrained model routes per-sample. p_r is a single distribution, the retain-set average softmax, and it is the same target for every forget sample. A retrained model does something different: it routes each forget-class image to whichever surviving class that particular image most resembles, giving an input-dependent output distribution. Matching p_r more closely therefore makes the model's predictions on forget data unnaturally homogeneous across samples. The agreement column is the evidence: as KL to p_r falls by one to three orders of magnitude, top-1 agreement with the reference *collapses* on two of the three classes ($45.4 \to 23.5$ on class 2, $38.7 \to 12.3$ on class 4). If p_r were the right

target, matching it better should have raised agreement. Class 3 moves the other way (31.2 → 39.8), so the effect is not universal.

Confound we cannot separate. KL to p_r decreases with training time while JS to the reference increases over the observed range, so the two are mechanically anti-correlated and the $\rho = -1.00$ figure partly reflects run duration rather than target quality alone. The agreement collapse is the part of the evidence that speaks to the target itself, and it rests on two of three classes. We therefore claim the criterion is refuted, and treat the mechanism as well-supported but not established.

J.5 What the experiment did establish

The FA rule overshoots its own target. All three FA-stopped runs halt at FA ≈ 7% against a target of 11.1% (the chance level), overshooting by 3.9–4.2pp, because the intra-epoch FA check is evaluated only every 50 batches. The over-forgetting we set out to explain is thus at least partly a *granularity* defect in how the existing criterion is enforced, not evidence that FA is the wrong quantity.

Less unlearning was better on every class. JS divergence to the retrained model is lower at the earlier stopping point in all three classes. Over the range we observe, the model is still moving toward the retrained reference when FA stopping halts it, and continues away from it afterwards. Combined with the overshoot above, this points to stopping *earlier and more precisely* rather than to replacing the stopped quantity.

Consequence for the method. We draw a narrower conclusion about `kl_retain` than the original formulation implies. As a forget-side *direction*, p_r is a better target than the uniform distribution (§4.3). As a *target to be minimised to zero*, it is actively harmful. Accordingly Eq. 2 states the forget condition on forget accuracy and uses the divergence only as the direction of the search, and we do not claim p_r is what a retrained model produces on forget inputs—the measurements here show it is not.

J.6 Open question

Where JS divergence to the retrained model is minimised along the unlearning trajectory remains unmeasured. Since JS is still falling when FA stopping fires and rising afterwards, a minimum exists between the base model and the FA-stopped point; locating it would establish whether a single FA level identifies it across classes, which would make it deployable, or whether it varies per class, which would not. This question is answered in §F.14: the minimum is interior, lies above the chance level, and the current rule stops past it.

K Ethical and Societal Considerations

Unlearning as evidence removal. A method that makes a model indistinguishable from one retrained without specific data could be misused to destroy evidence that problematic data was used for training. This is a dual-use property of the unlearning goal itself rather than of Excise specifically, but Excise does make it concrete. Partial mitigation is that Excise leaves an audit trail by construction: projection-rate logs, the FA trajectory, and retain-loss budget history are all recorded per run, so an auditor with access to the logs can establish that unlearning was applied and to what extent. We note this is mitigation, not prevention—an adversary who controls the logs controls the audit.

Selective fairness degradation. Class-level unlearning removes all samples of a class, which may correspond to a demographic group. Crucially, the accuracy degradation we observe is *not* confined to the forgotten class: test accuracy falls beyond what the removed class alone accounts for, and the per-class spread on PathMNIST (Appendix H) shows the effect is uneven across classes. Deployers should therefore monitor per-class accuracy before and after unlearning rather than only aggregate accuracy, which can conceal a disproportionate cost borne by one group.

Over-forgetting as a distinct harm. The PathMNIST finding (Appendix H) shows that a model can be pushed *past* the retrained reference. This matters ethically as well as technically: such a model is still

distinguishable from one trained without the data, so a deletion request has not been faithfully honoured, yet every FA-based check reports success. Compliance evidence resting on forget accuracy alone would be misleading here.

Regulatory gap. Approximate unlearning methods, including EXCISE, do not satisfy formal (ε, δ)-differential-privacy certification. Whether MIA AUROC ≈ 0.5 constitutes legally sufficient "erasure" under instruments such as the GDPR right to erasure remains an open legal question on which we take no position. The per-step guarantee of Theorem 1 is a statement about *retain-side utility*, not a privacy certificate, and should not be presented as one.

L Reproducibility

Artefacts. Code, YAML configuration files, per-run summary CSVs for all 75 runs, and the BatchNorm-recalibration diagnostic are released in the anonymised repository. **[TODO: Insert the anonymised repository URL.]** The archived $\mu = 0$ results underlying Table 5 are released alongside the main results, so the momentum ablation can be re-derived without re-running it.

Environment. PyTorch $\geq$ 2.0 with CUDA; ResNet-18 (11.7M parameters) throughout. Runs were executed on a single GPU. Datasets download automatically except PathMNIST, which is obtained through `medmnist`.

Implementation details that affect results.

- Momentum and weight decay are applied *manually* so that the projection acts on the post-momentum update; the underlying `torch` SGD object is configured with `momentum=0`, `weight_decay=0` and acts only as a plain step. Reading the optimiser construction alone is therefore misleading—see §4.2 and Appendix C.
- Clipping is applied to d_t before momentum accumulation, and *not* to the final update. Reversing this changes the effective step size by a factor $1/(1-\mu)$ (Proposition 2).
- The projected update is rescaled to the pre-projection norm.
- BatchNorm layers are set to `eval()` immediately after the model is set to `train()`, so running statistics are frozen during unlearning. BN-robust EXCISE (§6.5) instead recomputes them from 512 retain images before every step (`-bn_robust exact -bn_recal_samples 512`) and on the full retain set under test-time transforms after the last step. It reads the stopping forget accuracy under statistics recomputed from 10,240 retain images (`-bn_calibrated_stop -bn_stop_recal_samples 10240`), ships the best epoch when the target is not met (`-restore_best_epoch`), and uses an epoch cap of 25.
- The retain-confusion distribution p_r is precomputed once from the frozen original model.
- Forward hooks are registered on `layer3`, `layer4`, and `avgpool` for feature-level diagnostics.
- Configuration files set $c = 1.0$; the CLI default is 5.0 (see above).
- All baselines are re-run within the same codebase under a unified MIA protocol, rather than quoted from their source papers.

Determinism and seeds. Every 10-class task is run with seeds $\{42, 123, 456\}$ and reported as mean $\pm$ std; CIFAR-100 uses a single seed per class. Seed variance is small (Appendix H). As an internal consistency check, the two ablation variants that are no-ops under the shipped configuration (`-rep_weight 0`, `-forget_gate 0`, both already 0) produce byte-identical metrics, confirming both that the runs are deterministic given a seed and that those components are genuinely inactive.

Known reproduction caveats. The floating-point exactness of the guarantee is precision-dependent (Remark 3): reference implementations should accumulate the projection inner products in float64. Wall-clock timings depend on the GPU and on how early dual stopping fires, so step counts rather than seconds are the portable quantity.